

APPLICATIONS OF COMBINATORIAL AND TOPOLOGICAL GAMES IN CLASSICAL MATHEMATICS

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INTRODUCTION

In 1935 Stanisław Mazur wrote a problem in the Scottish Book, the notebook kept at the Scottish Café, in the beautiful city of Lwów, where the Polish mathematicians of the time did a good part of their thinking. Two players take turns choosing nested intervals of the real line, each inside the previous one, and the question is when the first player can force the point where the intervals close down to land in a given set. Banach found the answer, and Oxtoby published it in 1957. The game has been called the Banach–Mazur game ever since.

43) Definicja pewnej gry. Mazur

Dany jest zbiór E liczb rzeczywistych. Gra między graczami A i B polega na tem, że: A wybiera dowolny odcinek δ_1 , B następnie wybiera dowolny odcinek δ_2 zawarty w δ_1 , A następnie wybiera dowolny odcinek δ_3 zawarty w δ_2 i t. d.; A wygrywa jeżeli przekrój $\delta_1, \delta_2, \dots, \delta_n, \dots$ zawiera punkt z zbioru E , w przeciwnym przypadku przegrywa.

Jeżeli E jest dopełnieniem zbioru 1-ej kategorii, to istnieje metoda przy której A wygrywa; jeżeli E jest zbiorem 1-ej kategorii, to istnieje metoda przy której B wygrywa.

Problemat (Nagroda: 1 flaszka wina J. (Mazur))

Czy prawda jest, że dla E istnieje metoda wygrania tylko dla takich zbiorów E , których dopełnienie jest w jakimś odcinku 1-ej kategorii; podobnie czy metoda wygrania istnieje dla B tylko wówczas gdy E jest zbiorem 1-ej kategorii.

ad 43) Przypuszczenie Mazura jest prawdziwe. 4/VIII 35 Banach

FIGURE 1. Mazur's Problem 43 in the Scottish Book, in his own hand, with the prize he offered: "Nagroda: 1 flaszka wina" (a bottle of wine). Below, from the opposite page: "ad 43) Przypuszczenie Mazura jest prawdziwe. 4/VIII 35" ("Mazur's conjecture is true," 4 August 1935), signed by Banach. Courtesy of the Banach family, via the Stefan Banach Portal, Adam Mickiewicz University, Poznań (kielich.amu.edu.pl/Stefan-Banach).

It looks like a party game, and in a sense it is one, although admittedly a strange party. But it turns out to be a remarkably good way of thinking about *how big* a set is. A set is "large" if one of the players can always steer the game into it, and "small" if the other player can always steer the game away from it. Over the last sixty years people have changed the rules in all sorts of ways (prescribing the sizes of the moves, limiting how much the players may compute, letting them play vectors, points or covers instead of intervals), and each new version has cracked open a problem in some unexpected corner of mathematics. These notes tell twelve of those stories.

Part I is about the Banach–Mazur game itself and its close relatives, the games of Choquet type, in which the two players take turns shrinking a set:

Number theory: Schmidt’s games and badly approximable numbers (Schmidt, 1966).

Dynamical systems and Lie theory: Bounded orbits of flows on spaces of lattices: Margulis’s conjecture, proved by Kleinbock and Margulis (1996).

Theoretical computer science: Baire category inside complexity classes (Mehlhorn, 1973; Lutz, 1990).

Topological groups: When separate continuity implies joint continuity (Ellis, 1957; Namioka, 1974; Kenderov, Kortezov and Moors, 2001).

Functional analysis: Asplund spaces (Namioka–Phelps and Stegall, 1975; the game of Kenderov and Moors, 1999) and Gowers’s dichotomy for Banach spaces (Gowers, 1996).

Infinite-dimensional Ramsey theory: The Ellentuck topology (Ellentuck, 1974) and the Kastanas game (Kastanas, 1983).

Set theory: Nonprincipal ultrafilters on ω , the Baire property and the axiom of choice (Sierpiński, 1938; Talagrand, 1980), and Galvin’s games for selective ultrafilters and P-points.

Part II is about other famous topological games, mentioned by Frank, in which the players do not simply shrink a set:

Set-theoretic topology: The Menger game and the refutation of Menger’s conjecture (Fremlin and Miller, 1988).

Descriptive set theory: Borel determinacy (Martin, 1975) and the Wadge hierarchy (Wadge, 1972).

Part III tells the story of the Scottish Book: how it survived the war, how it travelled to Los Alamos, Denton and Toronto, and how the games it started came back to settle problems of Banach himself. The appendix collects three beautiful applications of games that are not topological at all:

Probabilistic combinatorics: The Erdős–Selfridge theorem and derandomization (Erdős and Selfridge, 1973).

Fixed point theory: Hex and the Brouwer fixed point theorem (Gale, 1979).

Model theory: Ehrenfeucht–Fraïssé games (Fraïssé, 1954; Ehrenfeucht, 1961).

The sections are independent of one another, apart from a few cross-references, and may be read in any order. The last section of Part I is the one where the Banach–Mazur game meets the axiom of choice head on: a nonprincipal ultrafilter on ω defines a game that nobody wins, and the same game shows that determinacy and nonprincipal ultrafilters cannot live together.

Here, for the record, is the game that started it all, in the form in which we will keep modifying it. Every game in Part I is this game with a few rules changed.

The Banach–Mazur game. Fix a set $S \subseteq \mathbb{R}$. Player I chooses a closed interval U_0 of positive length; Player II chooses a closed interval $V_0 \subseteq U_0$ of positive length; Player I chooses $U_1 \subseteq V_0$; and so on, forever. Player II wins if every point of $\bigcap_k V_k$ belongs to S . Theorem (Banach; Oxtoby, 1957): Player II has a winning strategy if and only if $\mathbb{R} \setminus S$ is meager, that is, if and only if S is “large” in the sense of Baire category.

Two features of games come back again and again. First, a winning strategy is built one move at a time, so a big global question (“is this set large?”) turns into a small local one

(“what should I play next?”). Second, strategies can be *combined*: a player can pursue several goals at once by taking turns between them, one round for this goal, the next round for that one. This is why sets defined by games survive countable intersections, something that measure and dimension simply do not do.

Conventions. We follow our notes on the Banach–Mazur and Choquet games. Player I moves first, Player II answers inside Player I’s move, and the payoff set belongs to Player II: she is the one trying to produce an object with a given property, and he is the one trying to stop her. Player I is the villain of every story in these notes, which is unfair to him, since he only wants to see whether Player II really knows what she is doing. Where an author used other names for the players (Spoiler and Duplicator, Maker and Breaker, ONE and TWO, β and α , and the least gamorous one — Alice and Bob), we say which of them is our Player I. Each section has the same shape: the problem, its history, the game, the main result, and how the game solves the problem.



(a)



(b)

FIGURE 2. The Scottish Café. (a) Plac Akademicki in Lwów, 1925; the café occupied the ground floor of the turreted corner building on the right, at ul. Akademicka 27 (today Prospekt Shevchenka 27). Photograph by Marek Münz; National Library of Poland (Polona), public domain. (b) The interior of the café in the 1930s; photographer unknown, public domain.

Part I. Applications of Banach–Mazur and Choquet games

1. APPLICATIONS TO DIOPHANTINE APPROXIMATION

The problem. Every real number can be approximated by fractions, but some numbers are much harder to approximate than others. For $t \in \mathbb{R}$ let $\|t\|$ be the distance from t to the nearest integer. A vector $\mathbf{x} = (x_1, \dots, x_n) \in \mathbb{R}^n$ is *badly approximable* if there is a constant $c = c(\mathbf{x}) > 0$ such that

$$\max_{1 \leq i \leq n} \|qx_i\| \geq cq^{-1/n} \quad \text{for every integer } q \geq 1.$$

For $n = 1$ this says $|x - p/q| \geq c/q^2$ for every fraction p/q . Let $\mathbf{Bad}(n)$ be the set of badly approximable vectors. Dirichlet’s theorem (1842) says that $\max_i \|qx_i\| < q^{-1/n}$ for infinitely many q , so badly approximable vectors are the ones for which Dirichlet’s theorem cannot be improved by more than a constant: they are the most stubborn vectors there are. How big is $\mathbf{Bad}(n)$? In particular, is the intersection of countably many translates of $\mathbf{Bad}(n)$ still big?

✂ **1.1. History of the problem and of the solution using topological games.** For $n = 1$ there is a pretty description: a real number is badly approximable exactly when the partial quotients in the continued fraction expansion are bounded. So the golden ratio $(1 + \sqrt{5})/2 = [1; 1, 1, 1, \dots]$, whose partial quotients are as small as they can be, is the most badly approximable number of all. Badly approximable numbers turn out to be both rare and common. Khintchine proved in 1924 that $\mathbf{Bad}(n)$ has Lebesgue measure zero, so a number chosen at random is almost surely *not* badly approximable. On the other hand, Jarník proved in 1928 that $\mathbf{Bad}(1)$ has Hausdorff dimension 1, the largest possible. So $\mathbf{Bad}(1)$ is tiny for measure and huge for dimension.

Neither measure nor dimension says anything useful about intersections: two sets of full dimension can be disjoint. So a question as innocent as “is there a number x such that $x + \sqrt{2}$, $x + \sqrt{3}$, $x + \sqrt{5}$, $\dots$ are all badly approximable?” was out of reach.

The problem was solved by Wolfgang Schmidt in 1966 [Sch66]. He invented a new version of the Banach–Mazur game, now called Schmidt’s game, proved that the winning sets of this game have full Hausdorff dimension and survive countable intersections, and showed that $\mathbf{Bad}(1)$ is a winning set. In 1969 he did the same for $\mathbf{Bad}(n)$ for every n [Sch69]. The game kept paying dividends. In 1983 Schmidt conjectured that for weights $i, j > 0$ with $i + j = 1$, the sets $\mathbf{Bad}(i, j)$ and $\mathbf{Bad}(j, i)$ of vectors in $\mathbb{R}^2$ that are badly approximable with weights (i, j) and (j, i) have a point in common, and he observed that a counterexample would prove the famous Littlewood conjecture. Badziahin, Pollington and Velani proved Schmidt’s conjecture in 2011 [BPV11], and in 2016 An showed that each $\mathbf{Bad}(i, j)$ is winning for Schmidt’s game [An16], which gives the conjecture, in a stronger form, from the intersection property.

Recognition. Schmidt received the Cole Prize in Number Theory in 1972, and he is one of the few number theorists invited to address the International Congress of Mathematicians three times. The solution of Schmidt’s conjecture by Badziahin, Pollington and Velani appeared in the *Annals of Mathematics*.

1.2. The game. Let (X, d) be a complete metric space, let $S \subseteq X$ be given, and fix two numbers $\alpha, \beta \in (0, 1)$. Schmidt called the players White and Black; in Choquet’s terminology our Player I is β and our Player II is α . The game is played with closed balls, and the radii are fixed in advance.

- (1) Player I chooses a closed ball $U_0 = \overline{B}(x_0, r_0)$ of any radius he likes.
- (2) Player II chooses a closed ball $V_0 \subseteq U_0$ of radius αr_0 .
- (3) Player I chooses a closed ball $U_1 \subseteq V_0$ of radius $\beta \alpha r_0$.
- (4) And so on: the play produces nested balls $U_0 \supseteq V_0 \supseteq U_1 \supseteq V_1 \supseteq \dots$, where U_k has radius $r_k = (\alpha\beta)^k r_0$ and V_k has radius αr_k .

The radii go to 0 and X is complete, so the balls close down on a single point x_∞ . Player II wins if $x_\infty \in S$. We call this game the (α, β) -game for S . The set S is α -winning if Player II has a winning strategy for every $\beta \in (0, 1)$. Notice the order of the quantifiers: Player II declares her handicap α first, promising to shrink by the factor α every time, and only then does Player I pick β , as aggressive as he likes. Her strategy is allowed to depend on β , but α is fixed once and for all. As the proof of Theorem 1.1(2) below shows, this order of quantifiers is what lets α -winning sets survive countable intersections. On the real line the balls are just closed intervals, and we speak of lengths instead of radii.

Compared with the Banach–Mazur game, the only new rule is that the sizes of the moves are prescribed. Player I can no longer shrink everything to a point in one move, and, as the proof of Theorem 1.1(1) below shows, this small change lets the game detect Hausdorff dimension.

1.3. The Main Result of this section. The main result consists of Schmidt’s theorems on his game (see the preceding subsection) and on badly approximable vectors.

Theorem 1.1 (Schmidt, 1966 and 1969). *Let $0 < \alpha < 1$ be given.*

- (1) *If $S \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ is α -winning, then $S \cap U$ has Hausdorff dimension n for every non-empty open set $U \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$.*
- (2) *The intersection of countably many α -winning subsets of $\mathbb{R}^n$ is α -winning.*
- (3) *The set **Bad**(1) is $\frac{1}{2}$ -winning, and **Bad**(n) is α -winning for suitable $\alpha > 0$.*

A translate of an α -winning set is α -winning (just translate the strategy), so by (2) the set $\bigcap_k (\mathbf{Bad}(n) + \mathbf{t}_k)$ is α -winning for every sequence of vectors $\mathbf{t}_k$, and by (1) this intersection has full dimension. In particular, there are (lots of) numbers x such that $x + \sqrt{p}$ is badly approximable for every prime p .

1.4. How the game solves the problem. We go through the three parts of Theorem 1.1, starting with the one that is pure number theory. For simplicity we prove that **Bad**(1) is α -winning for every $\alpha < \frac{1}{2}$; Schmidt’s sharper bookkeeping also handles $\alpha = \frac{1}{2}$.

Badly approximable numbers: the plan. Fix $\alpha < \frac{1}{2}$ and $\beta \in (0, 1)$, and let Player I open with an interval U_0 of length ρ_0 . Put $R = 1/(\alpha\beta) > 1$, so that every round shrinks the intervals by the factor R : the interval U_k has length $\rho_k = \rho_0 R^{-k}$. We will find a constant $c > 0$ and a strategy for Player II such that the final point x satisfies

$$\left| x - \frac{p}{q} \right| \geq \frac{c}{q^2} \quad \text{for every fraction } p/q \text{ with } q \geq 1.$$

Call the interval $(\frac{p}{q} - \frac{c}{q^2}, \frac{p}{q} + \frac{c}{q^2})$ the *no-go zone* of p/q . Player II’s job is to keep the final point out of every no-go zone. There are infinitely many zones, but she has infinitely many moves, and the whole proof is about giving each move a manageable amount of work.

Idea 1: fractions with small denominators keep their distance. If $p/q \neq p'/q'$, then

$$\left| \frac{p}{q} - \frac{p'}{q'} \right| = \frac{|pq' - p'q|}{qq'} \geq \frac{1}{qq'},$$

because $pq' - p'q$ is a non-zero integer. So two fractions whose denominators are both small cannot be close together. This little inequality is the engine of the whole argument.

Idea 2: sort the fractions into generations. Let $A = 1/(3\rho_0)$. Say that p/q belongs to *generation 0* if $q^2 < A$, and to *generation $k \geq 1$* if

$$AR^{k-1} \leq q^2 < AR^k.$$

Every fraction belongs to exactly one generation. Think of the generations as the octaves of a piano: we group the denominators by size, one octave per round, so that within a single octave all the fractions keep a respectful distance from one another. Generation k is the one Player II will deal with in round k . By Idea 1, two different fractions of generation k are at distance more than $1/(AR^k) = 3\rho_0 R^{-k} = 3\rho_k$. Now fatten Player I's interval U_k by ρ_k on each side; the fattened interval has length $3\rho_k$, so the fattened interval contains *at most one* fraction of generation k . If there is one, call that fraction the *dangerous fraction* of round k .

Idea 3: the no-go zones are small. A fraction p/q of generation $k \geq 1$ has $q^2 \geq AR^{k-1}$, so the no-go zone of p/q has length

$$\frac{2c}{q^2} \leq \frac{2c}{AR^{k-1}} = 6cR\rho_k.$$

Choose c so small that $6cR \leq 1 - 2\alpha$ and $2c \leq (1 - 2\alpha)\rho_0$ (the second condition takes care of generation 0, whose zones have length at most $2c$). Then every zone of generation k has length at most $(1 - 2\alpha)\rho_k$, which is less than ρ_k . In particular, a zone of generation k that reaches into U_k must belong to a fraction in the fattened interval, that is, to the dangerous fraction.

The strategy. In round k , Player II looks at Player I's interval U_k and at the no-go zone of the dangerous fraction of round k , if there is one. Removing the zone from U_k leaves at most two intervals, of total length at least $\rho_k - (1 - 2\alpha)\rho_k = 2\alpha\rho_k$, so one of them has length at least $\alpha\rho_k$. Player II plays her interval V_k inside that one. That is the whole strategy.

Why the strategy wins. Take any fraction p/q , and let k be the generation of p/q . The final point x lies in $V_k \subseteq U_k$. If the zone of p/q reaches into U_k , then p/q is the dangerous fraction of round k , and V_k avoids the zone of p/q , so x does too. If the zone does not reach into U_k , then $x \in U_k$ is outside the zone anyway. Either way $|x - p/q| \geq c/q^2$, so $x \in \mathbf{Bad}(1)$. The constant c depends on α , β and ρ_0 , which is fine, since the definition of $\mathbf{Bad}(1)$ allows each number a constant of its own.

Notice what the game has done for us. The condition “ $|x - p/q| \geq c/q^2$ for all fractions” involves infinitely many fractions at once; the game splits this condition into infinitely many small jobs, and each job (dodge one interval) is easy.

Higher dimensions. For $\mathbf{Bad}(n)$ the same plan works, with Idea 1 replaced by the *simplex lemma*: if $n + 1$ rational points in $\mathbb{R}^n$ with denominators $q_0, \dots, q_n$ do not lie on a common hyperplane, then the simplex they span has volume at least $1/(n!q_0 \cdots q_n)$. (The volume is $1/n!$ times a determinant whose entries are fractions with denominators q_i , and a non-zero determinant of that kind is at least $1/(q_0 \cdots q_n)$ in absolute value, exactly as in Idea 1.) Consequently, all the rational points of one generation that lie in a small ball sit on a single hyperplane, and in each round Player II has to dodge a thin slab around one hyperplane instead of one interval.

Full dimension. Suppose Player II has a winning strategy in the (α, β) -game for S . Inside Player II's ball V_k , of radius αr_k , Player I has room for roughly β^{-n} disjoint balls of radius $\beta \alpha r_k$, and he may play any of them. Let him try them all, while Player II keeps following her strategy. The result is a tree of plays: every ball has about β^{-n} children, and the radii

shrink by the factor $\alpha\beta$ from one generation to the next. The endpoints of all these plays form a Cantor set, and every point of this Cantor set lies in S , because Player II won every one of those plays. A Cantor set built this way has Hausdorff dimension at least about

$$\frac{\log(\beta^{-n})}{\log(1/(\alpha\beta))} = \frac{n \log(1/\beta)}{\log(1/\alpha) + \log(1/\beta)},$$

and this tends to n as $\beta \rightarrow 0$. Since an α -winning set is winning for *every* β , letting $\beta \rightarrow 0$ shows that such a set has dimension n . Starting inside any open set gives the local version.

Countable intersections. Let $S_1, S_2, \dots$ be α -winning. Player II becomes a time-sharer. She splits the rounds into infinitely many infinite arithmetic progressions, and in the rounds of the k -th progression she plays her strategy for S_k , ignoring everything else. From the point of view of S_k , everything that happens between two consecutive rounds of the k -th progression (her moves for the other sets and Player I's moves) just looks like one very big shrinking move by Player I, so the game for S_k is an (α, β_k) -game with a much smaller β_k . Since S_k is α -winning, Player II wins that game too. So the final point lies in every S_k . Player II's time-sharing strategy is a fugue: each voice enters at a time of its own and follows a line of its own, and in the end all of them sound together. Measure and dimension have no such trick, and this is the real reason games are useful here.

2. APPLICATIONS TO HOMOGENEOUS DYNAMICS

The problem. A *lattice* in $\mathbb{R}^m$ is a set of the form $g\mathbb{Z}^m$ with g an invertible matrix, and the lattice $g\mathbb{Z}^m$ is *unimodular* if $\det g = \pm 1$. The unimodular lattices form a space, which can be identified with $\mathrm{SL}(m, \mathbb{R})/\mathrm{SL}(m, \mathbb{Z})$. Flows on this space move lattices around by stretching some directions and squeezing others, for example

$$g_t = \mathrm{diag}(e^t, \dots, e^t, e^{-nt}), \quad t \geq 0,$$

acting on $\mathbb{R}^{n+1}$. For a flow of this kind almost every orbit is dense, so wanders all over the space, and the lattices whose orbits stay in a bounded region form a set of measure zero. How big is this set of measure zero?

Don't panic. This section uses the words “Lie group”, “lattice” and “horospherical subgroup”, but the heart of the matter is a computation with 2×2 matrices acting on the plane, which we do by hand below. The Lie group language is just the coordinate system that lets the same computation run in higher dimensions. If you understood Section 1, you already know the main idea: this section shows that the game you just played is secretly about lattices being stretched and squeezed.

2.1. History of the problem and of the solution using topological games. The space of lattices is not compact: you can squash a lattice to create a very short non-zero vector, and then squash further. Mahler's compactness criterion (1946) says that this is the only way to escape to infinity: a set of unimodular lattices is bounded exactly when the lengths of their shortest non-zero vectors are bounded away from zero. A lattice deep in the cusp is a very thin needle-like grid with a vector of length nearly zero. “Going to infinity” in this space is usually called “going into the cusp”.

The link with the previous section was found by Dani, who showed in 1985 [Dan85] that badly approximable vectors correspond exactly to bounded orbits of the flow above, and in 1986 used Schmidt's games to show that bounded orbits are abundant for several families of flows [Dan86]. In his plenary address at the International Congress of Mathematicians

in Kyoto in 1990 [Mar91], Margulis conjectured that this abundance is universal: for every one-parameter flow that is not quasi-unipotent (roughly, every flow that really stretches something), the set of points with bounded orbits is *thick*, that is, this set meets every non-empty open set in a set of full Hausdorff dimension.

The conjecture was proved by Kleinbock and Margulis in 1996 [KM96], by playing Schmidt's game on the expanding leaves of the flow. Later, Kleinbock and Weiss [KW13] introduced *modified Schmidt games*, adapted to flows that stretch different directions at different rates, and showed in 2013 that sets of bounded orbits are winning for them, which adds the countable intersection property to thickness. Winning has also been established for badly approximable points on planar curves, by An, Beresnevich and Velani in 2018 [ABV18].

Recognition. Margulis received the Fields Medal in 1978, the Wolf Prize in 2005 and the Abel Prize in 2020. Dani received the Shanti Swarup Bhatnagar Prize in 1990 and was an invited speaker at the International Congress of Mathematicians in Zürich in 1994. The dynamical approach to Diophantine approximation that grew out of this work led Kleinbock and Margulis to their proof of the Baker–Sprindžuk conjectures, by non-divergence estimates rather than games, in the *Annals of Mathematics* in 1998 [KM98].

2.2. The game. The game is Schmidt's game of Section 1, played not on the whole space but on an *expanding leaf* of the flow. The expanding horospherical subgroup H consists of the elements h with $g_{-t}hg_t \rightarrow e$ as $t \rightarrow \infty$; these are the directions that the flow stretches, like pizza dough. Since distances in these directions grow exponentially, a tiny ball soon becomes a ball of unit size, and this is what lets Player II deal with the problem one scale at a time. An orbit Hx is a copy of a nilpotent Lie group with a natural metric, and Player I and Player II play Schmidt's game with closed balls in Hx . Player II wins if the final point hx has a bounded orbit. For the diagonal flow above, the subgroup H consists of the matrices $\begin{pmatrix} I_n & \mathbf{y} \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, so the leaf through $\Lambda_0 = \mathbb{Z}^{n+1}$ is parametrized by $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, and the game on this leaf is literally Schmidt's game on $\mathbb{R}^n$.

2.3. The Main Result of this section. The main result consists of Dani's correspondence and the theorem of Kleinbock and Margulis.

Theorem 2.1 (Dani, 1985; Kleinbock–Margulis, 1996).

- (1) Dani's correspondence. *For $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$ let $\Lambda_{\mathbf{x}} = \begin{pmatrix} I_n & \mathbf{x} \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \mathbb{Z}^{n+1}$. Then $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbf{Bad}(n)$ if and only if the forward orbit $\{g_t \Lambda_{\mathbf{x}} : t \geq 0\}$ is bounded.*
- (2) Thickness of bounded orbits. *For every non-quasi-unipotent one-parameter subgroup of a connected semisimple Lie group G without compact factors, and every lattice Γ in G , the set of points of G/Γ with bounded orbits is thick.*

Part (1) says that Schmidt's theorem of Section 1 is secretly a theorem about one particular flow; part (2) says the same phenomenon happens for all flows that stretch.

2.4. How the game solves the problem. Let us see the whole mechanism in the simplest case $n = 1$, where everything can be computed by hand, and then explain what changes in general.

Lattices in the plane. For $n = 1$ we have $g_t = \text{diag}(e^t, e^{-t})$ and $u_x = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & x \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, so

$$\Lambda_x = u_x \mathbb{Z}^2 = \{(p + qx, q) : p, q \in \mathbb{Z}\}, \quad g_t \Lambda_x = \{(e^t(p + qx), e^{-t}q) : p, q \in \mathbb{Z}\}.$$

The flow stretches the first coordinate and squeezes the second, and the *product* of the two coordinates of a vector, namely $q(p + qx)$, does not change along the orbit. That invariant product is the whole story.

Dani's correspondence, by hand. Suppose first that $x \in \mathbf{Bad}(1)$, so $|p + qx| \geq c/|q|$ whenever $q \neq 0$. Take a non-zero vector $(e^t(p + qx), e^{-t}q)$ of $g_t\Lambda_x$. If $q \neq 0$, the product of the coordinates of this vector has absolute value $|q||p + qx| \geq c$, so the two coordinates cannot both be smaller than $\sqrt{c}$, and the vector has length at least $\sqrt{c}$. If $q = 0$, the vector is $(e^tp, 0)$ with $p \neq 0$, of length at least $e^t \geq 1$. So every lattice on the orbit has no non-zero vector shorter than $\min(1, \sqrt{c})$, and by Mahler's criterion the orbit is bounded.

Conversely, suppose that $x \notin \mathbf{Bad}(1)$. Then for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there are p and $q \geq 1$ with $|p + qx| < \varepsilon/q$. Choose the time t with $e^{-t}q = \sqrt{\varepsilon}$. At that time the vector coming from (p, q) has second coordinate $\sqrt{\varepsilon}$ and first coordinate $e^t|p + qx| < (q/\sqrt{\varepsilon})(\varepsilon/q) = \sqrt{\varepsilon}$, so this vector is shorter than $\sqrt{2\varepsilon}$. Since ε is arbitrary, the orbit dives deeper and deeper into the cusp and is unbounded.

So a good rational approximation p/q of x is *the same thing* as an excursion of the orbit into the cusp at time $t \approx \log q$.

The dictionary between scales and times. A one-line computation gives

$$g_t u_x g_{-t} = u_{e^{2t}x},$$

so the flow stretches the expanding leaf $\{u_x\Lambda : x \in \mathbb{R}\}$ by the factor e^{2t} . An interval of length ρ in the leaf is stretched to length about 1 at the time t with $e^{2t} \approx 1/\rho$. Now look again at the proof that $\mathbf{Bad}(1)$ is α -winning in Section 1. In round k , Player I's interval has length $\rho_k = \rho_0 R^{-k}$, and the fractions Player II worries about are those of generation k , with $q^2 \approx R^k$; by the computation above, these are exactly the fractions that send the orbit into the cusp at the time t with $e^{2t} \approx R^k \approx 1/\rho_k$. In other words, *round k of the game corresponds to the time at which the current interval has been stretched to unit size, and in that round Player II dodges the points whose orbits visit the cusp at that time.* Schmidt's proof, read in this dictionary, is a proof about orbits. The two proofs are the same story printed in a bilingual edition: number theory on the left page, dynamics on the right, and the formula $g_t u_x g_{-t} = u_{e^{2t}x}$ is the translator's note.

The general case. Kleinbock and Margulis play the same game for an arbitrary flow that stretches. Player II works on an expanding leaf Hx . In each round, she looks at Player I's ball, waits (in her head) until the flow has stretched that ball to unit size, and asks which points of the ball are deep in the cusp at that time. For the diagonal flow on the plane this bad set was a single short interval, the no-go zone of one fraction. In general there is no single dangerous fraction, and this is where the real work is: Kleinbock and Margulis show, using the mixing properties of the flow, that the bad set occupies only a small proportion of the ball, small enough that Player II can always find a ball of the prescribed size that avoids this region. The final point then never goes far into the cusp, and by Mahler's criterion the orbit of the final point is bounded. So the set of points with bounded orbits is winning on every expanding leaf, and hence of full dimension there.

From leaves to the whole space. Roughly, near any point the space looks like a product of a piece of an expanding leaf with the directions that the flow does not stretch, and whether an orbit stays bounded depends only mildly on those other directions. So full dimension on every expanding leaf gives full dimension in the whole space, that is, thickness.

3. APPLICATIONS TO COMPUTATIONAL COMPLEXITY

The problem. A *language* is a set L of finite binary strings, and a complexity class is a set of languages, such as P (decidable in polynomial time), the class $E = \text{DTIME}(2^{O(n)})$ (decidable in time $2^{O(n)}$ on inputs of length n) or $\text{SPACE} = \text{DSpace}(2^{O(n)})$. We would like to say that “most” languages in E are hard, or that “most” languages in SPACE need big circuits. Ordinary Baire category and Lebesgue measure on the space of all languages are useless for this: every complexity class is countable, hence meager and of measure zero, so that P and E look equally small. The problem is to find a notion of “small” that works *inside* a complexity class.

✂ **3.1. History of the problem and of the solution using topological games.** The problem was solved by Kurt Mehlhorn in 1973 [Meh73], who introduced resource-bounded Baire category, in which the descriptions of meager sets must themselves be computable with limited resources. In 1990 Jack Lutz reformulated the theory in terms of the Banach–Mazur game played with resource-bounded strategies [Lut90]. He proved, among other results, that languages with high circuit complexity are typical in SPACE in this sense, and in 1992 he introduced the companion notion of resource-bounded measure [Lut92]. These notions became standard tools for quantitative questions about complexity classes.

Recognition. Mehlhorn received the Leibniz Prize of the Deutsche Forschungsgemeinschaft in 1986.

3.2. The game. List all binary strings in the standard order, namely $\lambda, 0, 1, 00, 01, 10, 11, 000, \dots$ (shorter strings first, and strings of the same length in dictionary order). A language L is then the same thing as an infinite 0–1 sequence, the *characteristic sequence* of L , whose N -th bit says whether the N -th string belongs to L . A finite 0–1 string w is a partial description of a language, since w decides membership for the first $|w|$ strings. Note that the strings of length n occupy positions of size about 2^n in this list, so to decide all strings of length $< n$ we need a description of length about 2^n .

Let $\mathcal{C}$ be a class of languages.

- (1) The players alternately extend finite binary strings, $w_0 \sqsubset w_1 \sqsubset w_2 \sqsubset \dots$, with Player I playing w_{2k} and Player II playing w_{2k+1} .
- (2) The play produces the language $L = \bigcup_k w_k$.
- (3) Player II wins if $L \notin \mathcal{C}$.

This is the Banach–Mazur game on the Cantor space, and by the theorem of Banach and Oxtoby Player II has a winning strategy exactly when $\mathcal{C}$ is meager. The resource-bounded version adds one rule: *Player II is not allowed to think for too long*. Her strategy must compute each move in time polynomial in the length of the current string (or in space polynomial in that length, when we work in SPACE). A class is *meager in E* if Player II has such a strategy with the time bound, and *meager in SPACE* if she has one with the space bound. Player I has no restrictions at all.

3.3. The Main Result of this section. The theory rests on the fact that resource-bounded category satisfies a version of the Baire category theorem, so resource-bounded category can tell subclasses of a complexity class apart.

Theorem 3.1 (Mehlhorn, 1973; Lutz, 1990).

- (1) Baire category theorem. *The class E is not meager in itself in the resource-bounded sense.*
- (2) *The class P is meager in E in the resource-bounded sense.*
- (3) *The class SIZE($2^n/n$) of languages with circuits of size $2^n/n$ is meager in ESPACE in the resource-bounded sense.*

Part (3) says that big circuit complexity is typical in ESPACE. Lutz also proved the measure version: in resource-bounded measure, almost every language in ESPACE has circuit-size complexity above $2^n/n$ [Lut92]. Here category and measure agree, although, as on the real line, they can disagree in general.

3.4. How the game solves the problem. The game formulation makes the definition of category effective in the most natural way imaginable: one simply limits the resources of the winning player. The proofs then become constructions of efficient strategies, and they are pleasantly concrete.

The Baire category theorem: the class E is not meager in itself. Suppose Player II has a polynomial-time strategy. We show that Player I can make the play produce a language in E, so the strategy does not win the game for the class E. Player I's strategy is as lazy as possible: at each of his moves he appends a single 0. Now the whole play is computable. To decide whether the N -th string is in L , run the game until the current string has length at least N and read off bit N . Each round adds at least one bit, so at most N rounds are needed, and each of Player II's moves takes time polynomial in the current length, which is at most polynomial in N (she cannot write more bits than she has time for). So bit N is computed in time polynomial in N . Since the strings of length n sit at positions $N \approx 2^n$, membership of a string of length n is decided in time polynomial in 2^n , that is, in time $2^{O(n)}$. So $L \in E$.

P is meager in E: diagonalization, one move at a time. Let $M_1, M_2, \dots$ be a list of Turing machines in which M_i halts within $n^i + i$ steps on inputs of length n , so that every language in P is decided by some M_i . Player II wants to make sure that L disagrees with every M_i on at least one string. Here is her move. Suppose the current string w decides all strings of length less than s , so $|w|$ is about 2^s . For each $i \leq \log s$, Player II picks a fresh string x_i of length s that w has not decided yet, runs M_i on x_i , and extends w so that

$$x_i \in L \iff M_i \text{ rejects } x_i,$$

filling all the other new positions with 0. Each simulation takes at most $s^{\log s} + \log s$ steps, which is less than 2^s once s is large, so the whole move takes time polynomial in $2^s \approx |w|$, as the rules require. Player I may then extend the string as much as he likes, but he cannot undo what she wrote. Since Player II moves infinitely often and $s \rightarrow \infty$, every M_i is eventually defeated on some string, so $L \notin P$.

The one clever point is the restriction $i \leq \log s$. Player II cannot afford to simulate M_i on short strings when i is large, since n^i steps would blow her time budget, so she politely waits until the strings are long enough that M_i is cheap to simulate relative to $|w|$. For instance, if she tried to defeat M_{1000} in her very first move, the n^{1000} steps of the simulation would bankrupt her polynomial time budget on the spot. So she waits until $s \geq 2^{1000}$, when simulating M_{1000} is pocket change. This “diagonalization with delay” is a standard trick of complexity theory, and the game makes this trick look natural.

Circuit size: a counting argument, one length at a time. Here the resource bound is space instead of time, and the key fact is Shannon’s counting argument (1949). There are 2^{2^n} Boolean functions of n variables, one for each truth table. A circuit with s gates can be described by listing the operation and the two inputs of each gate, and a careful count (taking into account that renaming the gates does not change the circuit) shows that for large n there are fewer circuits of size $2^n/n$ than there are truth tables. So some Boolean function of n variables has no circuit of size $2^n/n$.

Player II uses this as follows. At her move, she takes the smallest length n such that no string of length n has been decided yet. She finds the first truth table on n variables that has no circuit of size $2^n/n$, by brute force: go through the truth tables one by one, and for each one go through all circuits of size $2^n/n$ and check whether any of these circuits computes that truth table. Then she defines L on the 2^n strings of length n to be that truth table. The search takes an astronomical amount of *time*, but very little *space*: at any moment she only needs to remember one truth table and one circuit, which takes space polynomial in 2^n , hence polynomial in the length of the current string. Space can be reused; time cannot. Player II’s search takes longer than the age of the universe, but she is only charged for the scratch paper. Since this happens for infinitely many n , the final language has no circuits of size $2^n/n$ at infinitely many lengths, so $L \notin \text{SIZE}(2^n/n)$.

4. APPLICATIONS TO TOPOLOGICAL GROUPS

The problem. A *semitopological group* is a group with a topology in which multiplication is *separately* continuous: the translations $x \mapsto xa$ and $x \mapsto ax$ are continuous. A semitopological group is a *topological group* if multiplication is jointly continuous and inversion is continuous. Separate continuity is much weaker than joint continuity (think of $f(x, y) = xy/(x^2 + y^2)$ on the plane, which is continuous in each variable separately but not at the origin). When does separate continuity of multiplication force a semitopological group to be a topological group? Behind this lies a more general question: when is a separately continuous function $f: X \times Y \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ jointly continuous at many points?

✂ 4.1. **History of the problem and of the solution using topological games.** Baire proved in his thesis of 1899 that a separately continuous function on $\mathbb{R}^2$ is jointly continuous at the points of a dense G_δ set. In 1957 Ellis proved that every locally compact Hausdorff semitopological group is a topological group [Ell57], and in 1974 Namioka proved a general joint continuity theorem for functions on $X \times K$, with X complete in a suitable sense and K compact, from which he deduced Ellis’s theorem [Nam74].

The game-theoretic solution came in three steps. In 1981 Christensen replaced the completeness hypothesis on X in Namioka’s theorem by the existence of a winning strategy in a topological game [Chr81]. In 1983 Saint-Raymond showed that the weaker hypothesis that the opponent has no winning strategy suffices, and deduced that every metrizable Baire space has the joint continuity property [SR83]. For groups, Bouziad proved in 1996 that every Čech-analytic Baire semitopological group is a topological group [Bou96], and in 2001 Kenderov, Kortezov and Moors introduced a game that describes a class of spaces, the strongly Baire spaces, on which every semitopological group is a topological group [KKM01].

4.2. **The game.** Let X be a space and $D \subseteq X$ a dense set. In the game $G_S(D)$ of Kenderov, Kortezov and Moors, their β is our Player I and their α is our Player II.

- (1) Player I chooses a non-empty open set $U_1 \subseteq X$.
- (2) Player II chooses a non-empty open set $V_1 \subseteq U_1$.

- (3) In general, Player I chooses a non-empty open $U_{k+1} \subseteq V_k$ and Player II a non-empty open $V_{k+1} \subseteq U_{k+1}$.
- (4) Player II wins if $\bigcap_k V_k \neq \emptyset$ and every sequence (a_k) with $a_k \in V_k \cap D$ has a cluster point in X .

A regular space is *strongly Baire* if, for some dense D , Player I has no winning strategy. This is the Banach–Mazur game with a more demanding winning condition for Player II; the games of Christensen and Saint-Raymond are variants in which Player II also picks points as she goes.

To see an example, let X be Čech-complete, say $X = \bigcap_k G_k$ with G_k open in a compactification bX . Player II wins with $D = X$ by choosing V_k whose closure in bX lies inside $G_k \cap U_k$. The closures form a decreasing sequence of non-empty compact sets, their intersection lies in X and equals $\bigcap_k V_k$, and every sequence with $a_k \in V_k$ clusters in $\bigcap_k V_k$.

4.3. The Main Result of this section. The main result consists of Namioka’s theorem, Ellis’s theorem, and the theorem of Kenderov, Korteov and Moors, which contains Ellis’s.

Theorem 4.1 (Ellis, 1957; Namioka, 1974; Kenderov–Kortezov–Moors, 2001).

- (1) Namioka’s theorem. *Let X be a Čech-complete space, let K be a compact space, and let $f: X \times K \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be separately continuous. Then there is a dense G_δ set $A \subseteq X$ such that f is jointly continuous at every point of $A \times K$.*
- (2) Ellis’s theorem. *Every locally compact Hausdorff semitopological group is a topological group.*
- (3) *Every semitopological group whose underlying space is strongly Baire is a topological group.*

Every regular Čech-complete space, in particular every locally compact Hausdorff space and every complete metric space, is strongly Baire, so part (3) contains part (2). Readers of our notes on stability will recognize the theme: the function f is jointly continuous at every point of $\{x\} \times K$ exactly when the map $x \mapsto f(x, \cdot)$ from X to $C(K)$, which is continuous for the topology of pointwise convergence, is continuous at x for the norm topology. So Namioka’s theorem is about upgrading pointwise convergence to uniform convergence, at least at many points.

4.4. How the game solves the problem. The arguments of Christensen, Saint-Raymond and Kenderov–Kortezov–Moors share a pattern worth learning; the arguments read a little like a detective story. Suppose, for instance, that multiplication is not jointly continuous at (e, e) . Then there is a neighbourhood W of e such that every pair of neighbourhoods of e contains elements u, v with $uv \notin W$. These pairs are the clues. Player I plays the Accuser, trying to prove that multiplication is guilty of discontinuity, and Player II plays the Defender. The Accuser uses the clues to build a strategy: at each move he chooses an open set inside Player II’s last move that records a new pair of witnesses, chosen so that separate continuity at any cluster point of the witnesses would be violated. Since X is strongly Baire, this strategy cannot be a winning one, so some play against this strategy is won by Player II. That play hands us a cluster point of the witnesses, and separate continuity at that point gives a contradiction. In short, the failure of joint continuity is turned into a strategy for Player I, and the topological hypothesis says exactly that such strategies can be beaten. Continuity of inversion is handled separately. For locally compact groups this gives Ellis’s

theorem; Namioka's original deduction, which uses translations to spread a single point of joint continuity over the whole group, follows the same idea.

5. APPLICATIONS TO BANACH SPACE THEORY

The problems. (1) *Differentiability of convex functions.* In calculus, a convex function of one variable is differentiable at all but countably many points. In infinite dimensions things are much less tidy. A Banach space X is an *Asplund space* if every continuous convex function on an open convex subset of X is Fréchet differentiable on a dense G_δ set. Which spaces are Asplund spaces?

(2) *The unconditional basic sequence problem.* Does every infinite-dimensional Banach space contain an unconditional basic sequence, that is, a sequence (e_n) that is a basis of the closed subspace spanned by (e_n) and for which every convergent expansion $\sum a_n e_n$ keeps converging when you flip the signs of the terms or shuffle their order?

✂ 5.1. **History of the problems and their solutions using topological games.** Mazur proved in 1933 that continuous convex functions on separable Banach spaces are Gâteaux differentiable on dense G_δ sets, and Asplund introduced the spaces now named after him in 1968, in a paper in *Acta Mathematica* [Asp68]. The characterization problem was solved in 1975 by Namioka and Phelps [NP75] and by Stegall [Ste75]. The game-theoretic description of the property behind Asplundness, fragmentability, was found by Kenderov and Moors and published in 1999 [KM99].

The unconditional basic sequence problem was one of the central open problems of Banach space theory for decades. The problem was solved, negatively, by Gowers and Maurey in 1992 (published in 1993) [GM93]. They built a *hereditarily indecomposable* space: a Banach space so tangled that no infinite-dimensional subspace splits as a direct sum of two infinite-dimensional subspaces. Gowers then showed, in 1996 and 2002, using an infinite game played with subspaces and vectors, that such strange spaces are not an accident: every Banach space contains either a subspace with an unconditional basis or a hereditarily indecomposable subspace [Gow96, Gow02].

Recognition. Gowers received the Fields Medal in 1998, for research connecting functional analysis and combinatorics, which includes the solution of the unconditional basic sequence problem and the dichotomy theorem. He was an invited speaker at the International Congress of Mathematicians in Zürich in 1994 and received the Prize of the European Mathematical Society in 1996. Gowers's Ramsey theorem appeared in the *Annals of Mathematics* in 2002.

5.2. The games.

5.2.1. *The fragmentability game.* Let K be a set with two topologies τ_1 and τ_2 ; for the dual ball B_{X^*} of a Banach space X , the topology τ_1 is the weak* topology and τ_2 is the norm topology.

- (1) Player I chooses a non-empty subset $U_0 \subseteq K$.
- (2) Player II chooses a non-empty relatively τ_1 -open subset $V_0 \subseteq U_0$.
- (3) In round $k \geq 1$, Player I chooses a non-empty subset $U_k \subseteq V_{k-1}$, and Player II a non-empty relatively τ_1 -open subset $V_k \subseteq U_k$.
- (4) Player II wins if $\bigcap_k U_k$ is empty, or if $\bigcap_k U_k$ is a single point x and every τ_2 -neighbourhood of x contains some U_k .

This is a Banach–Mazur game with a twist: Player I may play any non-empty set at all, while Player II must play relatively open ones, and she wins if the sets shrink down to a point in the stronger topology.

5.2.2. Gowers’s game. Let X have a basis (e_n) . A *block vector* is a non-zero finite linear combination of the e_n , and a *block subspace* is the closed span of a sequence of block vectors with successive supports. Let Σ be a set of sequences of normalized block vectors. In round $k \geq 1$, Player I chooses an infinite-dimensional block subspace Y_k , and Player II chooses a normalized block vector $x_k \in Y_k$. Player II wins if $(x_1, x_2, \dots) \in \Sigma$. Player I’s subspaces play the role of open sets. A block subspace can be chosen to live as far out along the basis as Player I likes, so by choosing such a subspace he can force Player II’s next vector to be supported beyond any finite stage, and he can restrict the kind of vectors available to her. In the Banach–Mazur game, a small neighbourhood plays exactly this role, limiting where the other player may look.

5.3. The Main Results of this section. Differentiability is tied to the dual space for the following reason. The derivative of a function on X at a point is a linear functional, an element of X^* , so differentiability is a question about how the candidate derivatives (the subgradients) sit inside X^* . Roughly, Fréchet differentiability at a point means that subgradients at nearby points are close to the derivative *in norm*, and the norm is what fragmentability controls. The first result collects several characterizations of Asplund spaces; one of them is exactly what the game of Kenderov and Moors detects. The second is Gowers’s dichotomy.

Theorem 5.1 (Asplund, 1968; Namioka–Phelps, 1975; Stegall, 1975). *For a Banach space X the following are equivalent:*

- (1) *the space X is an Asplund space;*
- (2) *every separable subspace of X has a separable dual;*
- (3) *the dual X^* has the Radon–Nikodým property;*
- (4) *the dual ball B_{X^*} , with the weak* topology, is fragmented by the norm: every non-empty subset of B_{X^*} has non-empty relatively weak*-open subsets of arbitrarily small norm diameter.*

Kenderov and Moors [KM99] showed that a space (K, τ_1) is fragmented by a metric whose topology contains τ_2 if and only if Player II has a winning strategy in the fragmentability game of the preceding subsection. In particular, if X is an Asplund space, Player II wins that game on B_{X^*} with the weak* and norm topologies.

Theorem 5.2 (Gowers’s dichotomy, 1996 and 2002). *Every infinite-dimensional Banach space contains an infinite-dimensional subspace that either has an unconditional basis or is hereditarily indecomposable.*

The two alternatives cannot happen at the same time, because a hereditarily indecomposable space contains no unconditional basic sequence. So every Banach space, however large, contains a subspace that is either perfectly civilized or thoroughly rebellious; there is no third option.

5.4. How the games solve the problems.

5.4.1. *Asplund spaces.* If K is fragmented by the norm, Player II has an easy strategy: answer each move U_k with a relatively weak*-open subset $V_k \subseteq U_k$ of norm diameter less than 2^{-k} . Then $\bigcap_k U_k$ has norm diameter 0 and is therefore empty or a single point x , and in the second case $U_{k+1} \subseteq V_k$ lies in the norm ball of radius 2^{-k} about x . Conversely, Kenderov and Moors build a fragmenting metric out of a winning strategy for Player II; roughly, two points are close when the strategy takes a long time to separate them. The advantage of the game is that a strategy is a local object, built one move at a time, while a fragmenting metric is a global one, and describing how to play is often much easier than writing down a metric.

5.4.2. *Gowers's dichotomy.* Gowers's infinite Ramsey theorem [Gow02] says that for every analytic set Σ and every sequence of positive tolerances, there is a block subspace Y such that either no block sequence of Y lies in Σ , or Player II has a winning strategy in the game played in Y for a slight enlargement of Σ , obtained by wiggling the members of Σ within the given tolerances. This is a game-theoretic version of the Galvin–Prikry and Ellentuck theorems on Ramsey sets (see Section 6 below), adapted to Banach spaces. An exact Ramsey statement is false for vectors, and the game is what can be rescued. Gowers's proof uses a “combinatorial forcing” argument, in which subspaces are said to accept or reject finite block sequences.

Roughly, the dichotomy follows by applying the Ramsey theorem to the set of block sequences that fail to be C -unconditional. If some block subspace avoids these sequences for some constant C , every block basis in that subspace is C -unconditional, so the subspace has an unconditional basis. Otherwise, in every block subspace Player II can produce badly unconditional block sequences, and from her strategies Gowers extracts a subspace in which no two infinite-dimensional subspaces form a direct sum, that is, a hereditarily indecomposable subspace. The game is what locates this subspace; the existence of such spaces is the theorem of Gowers and Maurey.

6. APPLICATIONS TO INFINITE-DIMENSIONAL RAMSEY THEORY

The problem. Ramsey's theorem (1930) says that if you colour the n -element subsets of $\omega = \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$ with two colours, there is an infinite $H \subseteq \omega$ all of whose n -element subsets get the same colour. We now colour the *infinite* subsets instead. Call $\mathcal{A} \subseteq [\omega]^\omega$, the set of infinite subsets of ω , *Ramsey* if there is an infinite $H \subseteq \omega$ such that $[H]^\omega \subseteq \mathcal{A}$ or $[H]^\omega \cap \mathcal{A} = \emptyset$. Using the axiom of choice one can build sets that are not Ramsey (a nonprincipal ultrafilter is one, as we shall see in Section 7). Which sets are Ramsey?

Ramsey's theorem in one picture: however wildly you splash two colours on the pairs of natural numbers, as in a Pollock, some infinite set has every pair of elements painted in a single colour, like a Rothko. There is a Rothko hiding in every Pollock. This section asks how far that remains true when we colour infinite sets instead of pairs.

- ✂ 6.1. **History of the problem and of the solution using topological games.** Ramsey's theorem appeared in 1930 [Ram30], and in 1952 Erdős and Rado showed, using the axiom of choice, that the infinite-dimensional analogue of Ramsey's theorem fails [ER52]. Nash-Williams proved in 1965 that clopen sets, in the topology inherited from the Cantor space, are Ramsey [NW65]; Galvin and Prikry extended this to Borel sets (published in 1973) [GP73], and Silver to analytic sets (published in 1970) [Sil70], by a proof that used metamathematical methods. Mathias developed the theory further, with applications to forcing, in his work on happy families [Mat77].

The problem was solved by Erik Ellentuck in 1974 [Ell74], who introduced a new topology on $[\omega]^\omega$, finer than the usual one, and proved that the sets that are Ramsey in a hereditary sense are exactly those with the Baire property in this topology. This gave a short proof of Silver's theorem. In 1983 Kastanas [Kas83] characterized the same sets by the determinacy of a game, which is a Banach–Mazur game in Ellentuck's topology. Gowers's game in Section 5 is the analogue of Kastanas's game for block sequences in Banach spaces.

6.2. The game. The game is played in a new topology, whose open sets look strange at first, so we begin with the idea. In the usual (Cantor space) topology on $[\omega]^\omega$, two infinite sets are close if they begin in the same way, that is, if they share the same finite initial segment s . Ellentuck's open sets ask for more: they fix the beginning s *and* restrict the rest of the set to come from a given reservoir M . For a finite $s \subseteq \omega$ and an infinite $M \subseteq \omega$ with $\max s < \min M$, let

$$[s, M] = \{X \in [\omega]^\omega : s \text{ is an initial segment of } X \text{ and } X \subseteq s \cup M\}.$$

Think of s as a stem that has already been decided and of M as the pool of candidates for the rest. These sets form a basis for the *Ellentuck topology*. A set $\mathcal{A}$ is *completely Ramsey* if for every $[s, M]$ there is an infinite $N \subseteq M$ with $[s, N] \subseteq \mathcal{A}$ or $[s, N] \cap \mathcal{A} = \emptyset$.

Let $\mathcal{A} \subseteq [\omega]^\omega$ be given, let $s \subseteq \omega$ be finite, and let $N \subseteq \omega$ be infinite with $\max s < \min N$. The Kastanas game $K(\mathcal{A}, s, N)$ is played as follows.

- (1) Player I chooses an infinite $M_0 \subseteq N$.
- (2) Player II chooses $n_0 \in M_0$ and an infinite $N_0 \subseteq M_0$ with $n_0 < \min N_0$.
- (3) In general, Player I chooses an infinite $M_k \subseteq N_{k-1}$, and Player II chooses $n_k \in M_k$ and an infinite $N_k \subseteq M_k$ with $n_k < \min N_k$.
- (4) Player II wins if $s \cup \{n_0, n_1, \dots\} \in \mathcal{A}$.

In Kastanas's paper the payoff set is Player I's; since the theorem is about determinacy and $\mathcal{A}$ is completely Ramsey exactly when the complement of $\mathcal{A}$ is, the switch does not matter. The moves are basic open sets in disguise: Player I's move M_k stands for $[s \cup \{n_0, \dots, n_{k-1}\}, M_k]$, and Player II answers with the smaller basic open set $[s \cup \{n_0, \dots, n_k\}, N_k]$. So this is a Banach–Mazur game in the Ellentuck topology, in which Player II must commit to one more element at each move.

6.3. The Main Result of this section. The main result is Ellentuck's theorem, in the game form due to Kastanas.

Theorem 6.1 (Ellentuck, 1974; Kastanas, 1983). *For $\mathcal{A} \subseteq [\omega]^\omega$ the following are equivalent:*

- (1) *the set $\mathcal{A}$ is completely Ramsey;*
- (2) *the set $\mathcal{A}$ has the Baire property in the Ellentuck topology;*
- (3) *for every finite $s \subseteq \omega$ and every infinite $N \subseteq \omega$ with $\max s < \min N$, the Kastanas game $K(\mathcal{A}, s, N)$ is determined.*

In any topological space, the sets with the Baire property are closed under the Souslin operation, and the analytic sets are obtained from closed sets by that operation. Since the Ellentuck topology is finer than the usual one, every analytic set, and in particular every Borel set, is completely Ramsey by Theorem 6.1. This recovers the theorems of Galvin–Prikry and Silver in one stroke.

6.4. How the game solves the problem. The theorems of Galvin–Prikry, Silver and Ellentuck all rest on the same device, the *combinatorial forcing* of Galvin and Prikry. We say that M *accepts* s if $[s, M] \subseteq \mathcal{A}$, and that M *rejects* s if no infinite $N \subseteq M$ accepts s . In plain words, the set M accepts the stem s if, however you complete s with infinitely many elements of M , you can never escape from $\mathcal{A}$; and M rejects s if no amount of thinning out M will make M accept s . By a diagonal argument one finds, inside any M , an infinite N that has decided every finite $s \subseteq N$, in the sense that N accepts or rejects each such s , and the decisions fit together. Ellentuck’s insight was that these diagonal arguments are exactly the proof that the Ellentuck space is a Baire space, and that the sets with $[s, N] \cap \mathcal{A} = \emptyset$ inside every $[s, M]$ are exactly the nowhere dense sets. Kastanas’s game turns the diagonalization into a play: a winning strategy for Player II, run against all possible moves of Player I and glued together by a diagonal fusion, produces an infinite $M \subseteq N$ with $[s, M] \subseteq \mathcal{A}$, and a winning strategy for Player I produces one with $[s, M] \cap \mathcal{A} = \emptyset$. So the Ramsey property is to Kastanas’s game what the Baire property is to the Banach–Mazur game.

7. APPLICATIONS TO ULTRAFILTERS

The problem. Identify every subset of ω with its characteristic function, so that the power set $\mathcal{P}(\omega)$ becomes the Cantor space 2^ω and a filter on ω becomes a set of reals. The axiom of choice provides nonprincipal ultrafilters on ω in abundance (there are $2^{2^{\aleph_0}}$ of them, the points of $\omega^* = \beta\omega \setminus \omega$), and yet nobody has ever exhibited one. The problem is to explain this: to determine how irregular a nonprincipal ultrafilter must be as a set of reals, how much choice its existence requires, and which ultrafilters are tame enough to carry the Ramsey theory of Section 6.

A principal ultrafilter is a point of ω in disguise: it collects the sets that contain the point, and its two-valued measure is the Dirac measure at the point. A nonprincipal ultrafilter is a point at infinity that passes judgement on every subset of ω , consistently and irrevocably, and always against the finite ones. Seen through Ulam’s binary version of the Banach–Mazur game, such a judge is invisible to topology: the game it defines has no winner. Seen through the games of Galvin, the well-mannered judges, the selective ultrafilters and the P-points, are exactly those that cannot be outplayed.

- ✂ **7.1. History of the problem and of the solution using topological games.** Ultrafilters came into mathematics through two doors. Tarski proved in 1930, using the axiom of choice, that every filter of subsets of a set extends to an ultrafilter [Tar30]; Stone made the ultrafilters of a Boolean algebra into the points of a compact space in 1936 [Sto36]; and Cartan introduced filters and ultrafilters in 1937 to describe convergence in general topology [Car37]. In 1938 Sierpiński observed that a nonprincipal ultrafilter on ω , regarded as a set of reals, is not Lebesgue measurable [Sie38]; the same symmetry shows that it does not have the Baire property. In 1962 Mycielski and Steinhaus proposed the Axiom of Determinacy, which makes every set of reals regular and therefore rules out nonprincipal ultrafilters on ω altogether [MS62]. Feferman showed in 1965, by forcing, that the existence of a definable nonprincipal ultrafilter on ω cannot be proved in ZFC [Fef65], and Shelah showed in 1984 that ZF together with the axiom of dependent choices is consistent with the statement that every set of reals has the Baire property, relative to ZF alone [She84]. Some choice beyond dependent choice is therefore needed to produce a single nonprincipal ultrafilter on ω .

Meanwhile the ultrafilters themselves were being sorted. Walter Rudin proved in 1956 that under the continuum hypothesis there are P-points, and deduced that ω^* is not homogeneous [Rud56]; Frolík proved in 1967 that ω^* is not homogeneous in ZFC [Fro67]. Booth and Kunen isolated the selective ultrafilters [Boo70], and Kunen proved that an ultrafilter is selective exactly when every colouring of $[\omega]^2$ in two colours has a homogeneous set in the ultrafilter. Mathias showed in 1977 that selective ultrafilters carry the Ramsey theory of analytic sets [Mat77]. Kunen proved in 1976 that it is consistent with ZFC that there are no selective ultrafilters [Kun76], and Shelah proved shortly afterwards that it is consistent that there are no P-points at all [Wim82].

The topological side of the problem was settled by Jalali-Naini in his thesis of 1976 [JN76] and, independently, by Talagrand in 1980 [Tal80], who characterized the meager filters by a combinatorial condition on interval partitions; Talagrand's motivation came from pointwise compact sets of measurable functions, the subject of the theory of Rosenthal compacta created by Bourgain, Fremlin and Talagrand. The games enter twice. The irregularity of a nonprincipal ultrafilter is a strategy-stealing argument in Ulam's binary game, implicit in Sierpiński's proof; and Galvin and McKenzie characterized the selective ultrafilters and the P-points by the games described below (see the book of Bartoszyński and Judah [BJ95]).

Recognition. Talagrand received the Abel Prize in 2024, and Shelah the Wolf Prize in 2001.

7.2. The games.

Ulam's game. Let $X \subseteq 2^\omega$ be given. In the game $G(X)$, Player I chooses a nonempty finite binary string s_0 , Player II chooses a nonempty finite binary string t_0 , Player I chooses a nonempty s_1 , and so on, forever. Player II wins if the concatenation

$$x = s_0 \frown t_0 \frown s_1 \frown t_1 \frown \dots$$

belongs to X . A move is a basic clopen set $N_s = \{x \in 2^\omega : s \subseteq x\}$ inside the previous one, so this is the Banach–Mazur game on the Cantor space, in the binary form proposed by Ulam (Section 11). The theorem of Banach and Oxtoby reads as follows here: Player II has a winning strategy in $G(X)$ if and only if X is comeager, and Player I has one if and only if $X \cap N_s$ is meager for some finite binary string s .

Galvin's games. Let $\mathcal{U}$ be an ultrafilter on ω . In the *selective game* $S(\mathcal{U})$, Player I chooses $A_0 \in \mathcal{U}$, Player II chooses $n_0 \in A_0$, Player I chooses $A_1 \in \mathcal{U}$, Player II chooses $n_1 \in A_1$, and so on; Player II wins if $\{n_0, n_1, \dots\} \in \mathcal{U}$. In the *P-point game* $P(\mathcal{U})$, Player II chooses a finite set $F_k \subseteq A_k$ instead of a single element, and wins if $\bigcup_k F_k \in \mathcal{U}$. Player I plays the sceptic: he keeps narrowing the field to sets that $\mathcal{U}$ approves of, and challenges Player II to assemble, one element (or one finite batch) at a time, a set that $\mathcal{U}$ approves of as well.

Recall that $\mathcal{U}$ is a *P-point* if for every partition of ω into pieces outside $\mathcal{U}$ some element of $\mathcal{U}$ meets every piece in a finite set, and that $\mathcal{U}$ is *selective* if some element of $\mathcal{U}$ meets every piece in at most one point.

7.3. The Main Result of this section. The main result collects the behaviour of nonprincipal ultrafilters in the two kinds of games.

Theorem 7.1 (Sierpiński, 1938; Mycielski and Steinhaus, 1962; Galvin and McKenzie). *Let $\mathcal{U}$ be a nonprincipal ultrafilter on ω , regarded as a subset of 2^ω . Then the following hold.*

- (1) *The game $G(\mathcal{U})$ is not determined.*
- (2) *The set $\mathcal{U}$ is neither meager nor comeager, it does not have the Baire property, and it is not measurable for the coin-tossing measure on 2^ω .*
- (3) *If the game $G(X)$ is determined for every $X \subseteq 2^\omega$, then every subset of 2^ω has the Baire property, and there is no nonprincipal ultrafilter on ω .*
- (4) *The ultrafilter $\mathcal{U}$ is selective if and only if Player I has no winning strategy in $S(\mathcal{U})$, and it is a P -point if and only if Player I has no winning strategy in $P(\mathcal{U})$.*

Part (2) explains why nobody has written down a nonprincipal ultrafilter on ω : analytic and coanalytic sets have the Baire property, so no nonprincipal ultrafilter is analytic or coanalytic. The proof of (3) works one pointclass at a time, and under projective determinacy (which follows from the Woodin cardinals of Section 9) every projective set has the Baire property, so no nonprincipal ultrafilter is projective either. The bound is sharp in Gödel's constructible universe, where a transfinite recursion along the Σ_2^1 well-ordering of the reals produces a Δ_2^1 nonprincipal ultrafilter. The proofs of (1) and (2) use only two properties of $\mathcal{U}$:

- membership in $\mathcal{U}$ does not depend on finitely many digits, because $\mathcal{U}$ is nonprincipal;
- the complement $\bar{x} = \omega \setminus x$ belongs to $\mathcal{U}$ if and only if x does not, because $\mathcal{U}$ is an ultrafilter.

7.4. How the games solve the problem.

Stealing a strategy. For a finite binary string s , we write $\bar{s}$ for the string obtained by flipping every digit of s . Suppose that σ is a winning strategy for Player II in $G(\mathcal{U})$. Player I plays two games against σ at the same time. In the first game he opens with the string 0, and σ answers t_0 . In the second game he opens with $\bar{0} \smallfrown t_0$, and σ answers u_0 . Back in the first game, he plays $\bar{u}_0$, and σ answers t_1 ; in the second, he plays $\bar{t}_1$, and σ answers u_1 ; and so on (Figure 3). After each round, the position in the second game is the flip of the position in the first, so the two plays x and y satisfy $y = \bar{x}$. Both plays are won by σ , so $x \in \mathcal{U}$ and $\bar{x} \in \mathcal{U}$, which is impossible. Hence Player II has no winning strategy.

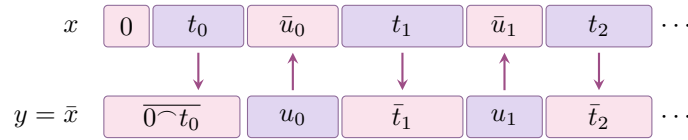


FIGURE 3. Stealing Player II's strategy in $G(\mathcal{U})$. Lavender blocks are answers of the strategy σ , blush blocks are moves of Player I, and each arrow copies an answer of σ in one game, flipped, as a move of Player I in the other.

Suppose now that Player I has a winning strategy τ , and let s be its first move. From the position s on, the strategy τ answers the moves of Player II and forces $x \notin \mathcal{U}$, that is, $\bar{x} \in \mathcal{U}$; flipping every move, we obtain a strategy that, from the position $\bar{s}$, answers its opponent and forces the play into $\mathcal{U}$. Player II can transplant this strategy into $G(\mathcal{U})$: she makes, if necessary, one dummy move, so that the position becomes longer than s ; at her next turn she pretends that the position is $\bar{s}$ followed by a single move of her opponent of the right length,

and from then on she answers as the flipped strategy does. Her play agrees with a play that the flipped strategy wins, except on finitely many digits, so she wins $G(\mathcal{U})$, which we have just seen to be impossible. This proves (1).

Baire property and measure. If X is comeager, then Player II wins $G(X)$ by playing, at her k -th move, into the k -th of countably many dense open sets whose intersection lies in X ; if X is meager, then Player I wins in the same way. By (1), the set $\mathcal{U}$ is therefore neither meager nor comeager. A set $X \subseteq 2^\omega$ that is invariant under finite changes and has the Baire property is meager or comeager. Indeed, if X is not meager, then $N_s \setminus X$ is meager for some s , and for every string t of the same length as s the homeomorphism of 2^ω that replaces the initial segment s by t carries N_s to N_t and preserves X ; the finitely many sets N_t cover 2^ω . Hence $\mathcal{U}$ does not have the Baire property. Measure is no better. The flip $x \mapsto \bar{x}$ preserves the coin-tossing measure λ and carries $\mathcal{U}$ onto its complement, so if $\mathcal{U}$ were measurable we would have $\lambda(\mathcal{U}) = 1 - \lambda(\mathcal{U}) = \frac{1}{2}$, while Kolmogorov's zero-one law, applied to a measurable set that is invariant under finite changes, gives $\lambda(\mathcal{U}) \in \{0, 1\}$. This proves (2).

Determinacy kills ultrafilters. Assume that every game $G(X)$ is determined, and let $X \subseteq 2^\omega$ and a string s be given. Applying determinacy to the set $\{z : s \frown z \in X\}$ and the theorem of Banach and Oxtoby, we find a string $s' \supseteq s$ such that X is comeager in $N_{s'}$ or meager in $N_{s'}$. Let O be the union of the sets $N_{s'}$ in which X is comeager, and let O' be the union of those in which X is meager. Then $O \cup O'$ is a dense open set, and $X \triangle O$ is contained in the union of $O \setminus X$, of $O' \cap X$, and of the nowhere dense set $2^\omega \setminus (O \cup O')$, all of which are meager. Hence X has the Baire property, and by (2) there is no nonprincipal ultrafilter on ω . The same argument, applied to the sets of a pointclass that is closed under continuous preimages, gives the remarks after Theorem 7.1.

Meager filters. The game argument shows that a nonprincipal ultrafilter is not meager; the following theorem shows exactly how much of the ultrafilter property is responsible.

Theorem 7.2 (Jalali-Naini, 1976; Talagrand, 1980). *Let $\mathcal{F}$ be a filter on ω that contains every cofinite set. Then $\mathcal{F}$ is meager, as a subset of 2^ω , if and only if there is a partition of ω into consecutive finite intervals $I_0 < I_1 < \dots$ such that every element of $\mathcal{F}$ meets all but finitely many of the I_n .*

Proof. If such a partition exists, then $\mathcal{F}$ is contained in the union over m of the sets $\{x : x \cap I_n \neq \emptyset \text{ for all } n \geq m\}$. These sets are closed, and nowhere dense, because any finite string can be extended by zeros across a whole interval I_n . For the converse, let $C_0 \subseteq C_1 \subseteq \dots$ be closed nowhere dense sets whose union contains $\mathcal{F}$. We choose $0 = n_0 < n_1 < \dots$ and binary strings w_k of length $n_{k+1} - n_k$ such that $N_{u \frown w_k} \cap C_k = \emptyset$ for every string u of length n_k . This is possible because there are only finitely many such u , and we may extend a candidate for w_k once for each of them, each time avoiding C_k . Let $I_k = [n_k, n_{k+1})$ and let $e \subseteq \omega$ be the set whose characteristic function is $w_0 \frown w_1 \frown \dots$. If $z \in C_m$, then z does not agree with e on I_k for any $k \geq m$. Now let $x \in \mathcal{F}$ be given. Then $x \cup e \in \mathcal{F}$, so $x \cup e \in C_m$ for some m , and for every $k \geq m$ the sets $x \cup e$ and e differ somewhere in I_k , which means that x meets I_k . 

A nonprincipal ultrafilter $\mathcal{U}$ fails the condition of Theorem 7.2 for every partition: the union of the even intervals and the union of the odd intervals are complementary, so one of them belongs to $\mathcal{U}$, and it misses infinitely many intervals. This is a second proof that $\mathcal{U}$ is not meager. Theorem 7.2 also shows that nonmeagerness survives finite-to-one images: if $f: \omega \rightarrow \omega$ is finite-to-one and $f(\mathcal{F})$ is meager, witnessed by a partition $\{I_n\}$, then any partition of ω into consecutive intervals each of which contains one of the finite sets $f^{-1}(I_n)$ witnesses that $\mathcal{F}$ is meager.

Selective ultrafilters. Suppose that $\mathcal{U}$ is selective, and let τ be a strategy for Player I in $S(\mathcal{U})$. For a finite set $s \subseteq \omega$, listed increasingly, let $A_s \in \mathcal{U}$ be the move of τ after Player II has played the elements of s , and let $B_n = \bigcap \{A_s : s \subseteq \{0, \dots, n-1\}\}$, a finite intersection, so that $B_n \in \mathcal{U}$. Colour a pair $m < n$ pink if $n \in B_{m+1}$ and purple otherwise. By Kunen's theorem there is a homogeneous set $H \in \mathcal{U}$, and we may shrink it so that $H \subseteq A_\emptyset$. The colour of H is not purple, because for $m = \min H$ the sets $H \setminus \{m\}$ and B_{m+1} both belong to $\mathcal{U}$ and so they meet. So the colour is pink. List H increasingly as $h_0 < h_1 < \dots$. Then $h_0 \in A_\emptyset$, and $h_{k+1} \in B_{h_k+1} \subseteq A_{\{h_0, \dots, h_k\}}$ for every k . Hence Player II may answer τ with $h_0, h_1, h_2, \dots$ in turn, and the set she produces is $H \in \mathcal{U}$. So τ is not a winning strategy. Conversely, if $\mathcal{U}$ is not selective, fix a partition $\{P_j\}$ of ω into pieces outside $\mathcal{U}$ such that no element of $\mathcal{U}$ meets every piece in at most one point. Player I wins by always removing the pieces already visited: when Player II has played elements of $P_{j_0}, \dots, P_{j_{k-1}}$, he plays $\omega \setminus (P_{j_0} \cup \dots \cup P_{j_{k-1}})$, which belongs to $\mathcal{U}$; then the set produced by Player II meets each piece at most once, and so it is not in $\mathcal{U}$. The P-point game is handled by the same two arguments, with finite sets in place of single points and the P-point property in place of homogeneity; we refer to [BJ95].

Selectivity is exactly what the Ramsey theory of Section 6 needs. Mathias proved that if $\mathcal{U}$ is selective, then every analytic $\mathcal{A} \subseteq [\omega]^\omega$ has a homogeneous set in $\mathcal{U}$: there is $H \in \mathcal{U}$ with $[H]^\omega \subseteq \mathcal{A}$ or $[H]^\omega \cap \mathcal{A} = \emptyset$ [Mat77]. An ultrafilter cannot do this for itself: however we choose an infinite H , splitting H into two infinite halves yields two elements of $[H]^\omega$, exactly one of which belongs to $\mathcal{U}$. So every nonprincipal ultrafilter is a set that is not Ramsey, and it is the simplest one that the axiom of choice provides.

Points that nobody can point at. The space ω^* is the Stone space of the Boolean algebra $\mathcal{P}(\omega)/\text{fin}$, and its points are the nonprincipal ultrafilters on ω . Pospíšil showed in 1937 that there are $2^{2^{\aleph_0}}$ of them, by means of an independent family of $2^{\aleph_0}$ subsets of ω in the sense of Fichtenholz, Kantorovich and Hausdorff: every Boolean combination of finitely many members of the family is infinite, so every assignment of signs to the members extends to an ultrafilter. A P-point is exactly a point $p \in \omega^*$ such that every G_δ subset of ω^* containing p is a neighbourhood of p , and no homeomorphism of ω^* can move a P-point to the limit of a countable discrete subset of ω^* ; this is Rudin's proof of non-homogeneity under the continuum hypothesis. Kunen found in ZFC, in 1978, *weak P-points*, points that are not limits of any countable subset of the rest of ω^* [Kun80]. All of these points are produced by choice, and part (3) of Theorem 7.1 says that none of them can be produced by a definition of low complexity. The large-cardinal picture is sharper still: Todorćević proved that, in the presence of large cardinals, the selective ultrafilters are exactly the filters that are generic over $L(\mathbb{R})$ for the partial order $\mathcal{P}(\omega)/\text{fin}$ (see Farah [Far98]). A selective ultrafilter is thus a generic object for the very Boolean algebra whose Stone space it inhabits, and every statement about it in $L(\mathbb{R})$ is decided by the forcing relation, the way a statement about a Cohen real is decided by finite conditions.

Part II. Applications of other topological games

8. APPLICATIONS TO SET-THEORETIC TOPOLOGY

The problem. Compact sets are the “small” sets of topology, and countable unions of compact sets (σ -compact sets) are almost as tame. In 1924 Karl Menger proposed a covering property that looked like a clean characterization of σ -compactness. A space X has the *Menger property* if for every sequence $\mathcal{U}_1, \mathcal{U}_2, \dots$ of open covers of X there are finite sets $\mathcal{F}_n \subseteq \mathcal{U}_n$ such that $\bigcup_n \mathcal{F}_n$ covers X . Every σ -compact space has the Menger property: if $X = \bigcup_n K_n$ with K_n compact, choose $\mathcal{F}_n$ to be a finite subset of $\mathcal{U}_n$ that covers K_n . Menger conjectured the converse for metric spaces. The problem is to decide Menger’s conjecture, in particular for sets of real numbers.

✂ **8.1. History of the problem and of the solution using topological games.** Menger introduced the property in 1924 [Men24], in a different but equivalent form, while studying a basis property of metric spaces, and conjectured that this property characterizes σ -compactness. Hurewicz gave the property the form above in 1925 [Hur26], found a characterization by an infinite game, and introduced a stronger property for which he made the analogous conjecture. Under the continuum hypothesis the conjecture fails: a Luzin set, an uncountable set of reals meeting every meager set in a countable set, has the Menger property but is not σ -compact. In 1975 Telgársky characterized σ -compactness by the same game [Tel75], so that Menger’s conjecture became the statement that the Menger game on a set of reals is always determined.

The problem was solved by David Fremlin and Arnold Miller in 1988 [FM88], who constructed, in ZFC, a set of reals with the Menger property that is not σ -compact. The closely related property of Rothberger (1938), in which a single member of each cover is chosen, has a parallel game-theoretic story: Galvin introduced the point-open game in 1978 [Gal78], and in 1994 Pawlikowski proved that a set of reals is undetermined in this game if and only if the set is uncountable and has Rothberger’s property [Paw94]. Borel conjectured in 1919 that every set of reals of strong measure zero is countable, and Laver proved in 1976 that this is consistent [Lav76]. Since Rothberger’s property implies strong measure zero, in Laver’s model every set of reals is determined in the point-open game, while under the continuum hypothesis a Luzin set gives an undetermined one [Rec94].

8.2. The games. In the *Menger game* on X , in round n Player I opens an umbrella: he chooses an open cover $\mathcal{U}_n$ of the whole space X , and Player II chooses a finite set $\mathcal{F}_n \subseteq \mathcal{U}_n$. Player II wins if $\bigcup_n \mathcal{F}_n$ covers X . In the *Rothberger game* Player II must be even more frugal and chooses a single member of each cover. In the literature Player I is called ONE and Player II is called TWO. In Galvin’s *point-open game*, Player I chooses a point $x_n \in X$ and Player II an open set $U_n \ni x_n$, and Player II wins if the sets U_n do not cover X ; the point-open game is dual to the Rothberger game, in the sense that a winning strategy for either player in one game corresponds to a winning strategy for the other player in the other game. Watch out for the reversal: in the Menger and Rothberger games Player II wants her umbrellas to keep all of X dry, while in Galvin’s game she places the umbrellas but wants to leave some spot out in the rain.

8.3. The Main Result of this section. The main result consists of the game characterizations of the Menger property and of σ -compactness, and the theorem of Fremlin and Miller.

Theorem 8.1 (Hurewicz, 1925; Telgársky, 1975; Fremlin–Miller, 1988).

- (1) *A space X has the Menger property if and only if Player I has no winning strategy in the Menger game on X .*
- (2) *A separable metrizable space X is σ -compact if and only if Player II has a winning strategy in the Menger game on X .*
- (3) *There is a set of reals with the Menger property that is not σ -compact. Consequently, the Menger game on this set is not determined, and Menger’s conjecture is false.*

8.4. How the games solve the problem.

Menger’s property. If Player I has no winning strategy, then, given covers $\mathcal{U}_1, \mathcal{U}_2, \dots$, the strategy “play $\mathcal{U}_n$ in round n ” is not winning, so some play against this strategy is won by Player II, and her moves witness the Menger property. The converse is the substantial direction: a strategy for Player I produces only countably many covers, one for each finite position, since a Lindelöf space allows Player I’s covers to be taken countable, and Hurewicz applies the Menger property to a suitable arrangement of these covers to build a play that defeats the strategy.

σ -compactness. If $X = \bigcup_n K_n$ with K_n compact and increasing, Player II wins by choosing, in round n , a finite subfamily of $\mathcal{U}_n$ that covers K_n . Conversely, Telgársky unravels a winning strategy of Player II, position by position, into countably many compact sets that cover X .

Menger’s conjecture. By parts (1) and (2), a separable metrizable space with the Menger property that is not σ -compact is exactly one on which neither player has a winning strategy. Fremlin and Miller construct such a set of reals from combinatorial properties of families of functions in ω^ω under eventual domination; the link is a theorem of Hurewicz, which says that a subset of ω^ω has the Menger property exactly when no continuous image of the subset in ω^ω is a dominating family. The point of view of games explains both the appeal and the failure of the conjecture. The appeal is that the conjecture asserts a form of determinacy, and determinacy holds for well-behaved sets (for analytic sets of reals the conjecture is in fact true). The failure comes from wild sets, on which games need not be determined, and Fremlin and Miller found a wild enough set without any extra axioms.

9. APPLICATIONS TO DESCRIPTIVE SET THEORY

The problem. Here is the simplest infinite game imaginable. Fix a set $A \subseteq \omega^\omega$ of infinite sequences of natural numbers. In the *Gale–Stewart game* $G(A)$, Player I and Player II take turns calling out natural numbers, Player I playing $x(0), x(2), \dots$ and Player II playing $x(1), x(3), \dots$, and Player II wins if the resulting sequence x belongs to A . The game is *determined* if one of the players has a winning strategy. For finite games this is always the case (that is Zermelo’s theorem, which is why chess has an optimal strategy that nobody knows). For infinite games determinacy can fail: using the axiom of choice one can build sets A for which neither player has a winning strategy (a nonprincipal ultrafilter on ω gives one, by Theorem 7.1). Which sets, and in particular which Borel sets, give determined games? And what does the answer tell us about the structure of the Borel sets?

- ✂ 9.1. **History of the problem and of the solution using infinite games.** The story of this problem is unusual: the game came first, and the applications came later. Gale and Stewart introduced these games in 1953 [GS53], proved that $G(A)$ is determined when

A is open or closed, constructed an undetermined game from a well-ordering of the reals, and asked how far determinacy extends. Wolfe proved in 1955 that games with F_σ or G_δ payoff sets are determined [Wol55], and Davis extended this in 1964 to the next level of the Borel hierarchy [Dav64]. In 1970 Martin proved that analytic games are determined if there is a measurable cardinal [Mar70], and in 1971 Friedman showed that any proof of Borel determinacy must use uncountably many iterations of the power set operation [Fri71], so that the problem could not be solved by the methods of ordinary analysis. A statement about sets of real numbers that needs sets of sets of sets of $\dots$ of reals, iterated uncountably many times, for a proof of that statement: that was something new.

The problem was solved by Donald A. Martin in 1975 [Mar75], who proved that every Borel game is determined. Martin's argument may well be the most expensive proof ever written of a statement about sets of real numbers. Even before this, Wadge had shown in his work of 1972, written up in his thesis of 1983 [Wad83], that determinacy turns the Borel sets into a hierarchy that is essentially a well-ordering, by comparing sets through a game of his own. The theory was later extended far beyond the Borel sets: Martin and Steel proved in 1989 that projective games are determined if there are infinitely many Woodin cardinals [MS89].

Recognition. Martin's proof appeared in the *Annals of Mathematics*. Martin, Steel and Woodin received the Karp Prize of the Association for Symbolic Logic in 1988 for their work on determinacy, and the proof of projective determinacy by Martin and Steel appeared in the *Journal of the American Mathematical Society*.

9.2. The games. The Gale–Stewart game $G(A)$ was defined in the statement of the problem at the beginning of this section. The *Wadge game* $W(A, B)$ is a clever way of comparing two sets. Think of Player II as trying to imitate Player I: whenever his sequence lands in A , hers should land in B , and vice versa. Player I plays $x(0), x(1), \dots$ and Player II plays $y(0), y(1), \dots$, alternately, Player I first, and Player II wins if

$$x \in A \iff y \in B.$$

This is a Gale–Stewart game whose payoff set is Borel when A and B are.

9.3. The Main Result of this section. The main result consists of Martin's theorem together with a consequence for the comparison of Borel sets. For $A, B \subseteq \omega^\omega$ write $A \leq_W B$, and say that A is *Wadge reducible* to B , if there is a continuous $f: \omega^\omega \rightarrow \omega^\omega$ with $A = f^{-1}(B)$.

Theorem 9.1 (Martin, 1975; Wadge, 1972).

- (1) Borel determinacy. *For every Borel set $A \subseteq \omega^\omega$, the game $G(A)$ is determined.*
- (2) Wadge's lemma. *For all Borel sets $A, B \subseteq \omega^\omega$, either $A \leq_W B$ or $B \leq_W \omega^\omega \setminus A$.*

By part (2), any two Borel sets are comparable under $\leq_W$, up to complements. Martin and Monk showed that $\leq_W$ is also well-founded on the Borel sets, so the Borel sets, up to Wadge equivalence, form a hierarchy indexed by ordinals that refines the classical Borel hierarchy. Borel determinacy thus arranges the Borel sets in a hierarchy as orderly as Dante's circles, each level strictly more complex than the one below.

9.4. How the games solve the problem.

Open games. Suppose that A is open and that Player II has no winning strategy in $G(A)$. We shall call a finite position *good for Player I* if Player II has no winning strategy from that position. If a position with Player I to move is good for him, some move keeps the position good, for otherwise Player II would have a winning strategy from every successor position

and hence from the position itself; if a position with Player II to move is good for Player I, so is every position reached in one move. So Player I can play forever through good positions. If the resulting x were in A , then, since A is open, some initial segment of x would already force the play into A , and Player II would win trivially from that position, which would not be good for Player I. Hence $x \notin A$, and Player I has a winning strategy. The idea is simply “never step into a position from which you are already lost”; the openness of A guarantees that this cautious play is enough.

Borel games. Martin’s proof reduces every Borel game to an open game on a larger tree. Roughly, for each Borel set A he builds a game G' whose moves are more complicated objects than natural numbers, together with a map from plays of G' to plays of $G(A)$ that sends strategies to strategies, such that the payoff set of G' is clopen and corresponds to A . Since G' is determined by the Gale–Stewart theorem, so is $G(A)$. The construction proceeds by induction on the Borel rank of A , and at each step the moves of the new game are sets of positions of the old one; this is why Martin’s proof climbs through the iterated power sets of $\mathbb{R}$, in agreement with Friedman’s theorem.

Wadge’s lemma. By Borel determinacy, one of the players has a winning strategy in $W(A, B)$. If Player II has one, her strategy is literally a blueprint for a continuous function: Player I feeds in an input sequence x one digit at a time, and Player II’s step-by-step answers are the output y . Since each output digit depends only on finitely many input digits, the map $x \mapsto y$ is continuous, and $x \in A$ if and only if $y \in B$, so $A \leq_W B$. If Player I has one, his strategy turns each sequence y of moves of Player II into a sequence x continuously, with $y \in B$ if and only if $x \notin A$, so $B \leq_W \omega^\omega \setminus A$. The game thus produces the reduction itself, and the comparability of Borel sets is literally the determinacy of a game.

Part III. The Scottish Book, von Neumann, Ulam, Texas, Toronto, and the triumph of games, logic, topology and combinatorics

This part is about the people behind the mathematics of these notes: where they worked, what happened to them, and how their problems travelled. Many of them were very young. When the Scottish Book was started, in the summer of 1935, Stanisław Ulam was twenty-six, Stanisław Mazur was thirty, Mark Kac was twenty, and Stefan Banach, who led the discussions at the café table, was forty-three. Figure 4 shows the journey of the Scottish Book and of the people who carried it, and Figure 5 is a timeline to keep at hand while reading.

10. THE MARBLE TABLES OF THE SCOTTISH CAFÉ

In the interwar years, the city of Lwów (then in southeastern Poland, now Lviv, Ukraine) was home to one of the most vibrant mathematical communities in history. Led by Stefan Banach and Hugo Steinhaus, with Stanisław Mazur, Juliusz Schauder, Stanisław Ulam, Mark Kac and many others, the Lwów School did much to create modern functional analysis. Through Mazur’s Problem 43 it also produced the first infinite game in topology.

The school began with a chance meeting. One evening in 1916, walking in the Planty, the park around the old town of Kraków, Steinhaus overheard the words “Lebesgue integral” and stopped to talk to the two young men who had said them. They were Stefan Banach and Otto Nikodym. Banach, then twenty-four, had studied engineering in Lwów without finishing his degree, and was teaching himself mathematics. Steinhaus told him about a problem he was working on; a few days later Banach brought him the solution, and their first joint paper followed. In 1920, with Steinhaus’s support, Banach was allowed to submit a doctoral thesis

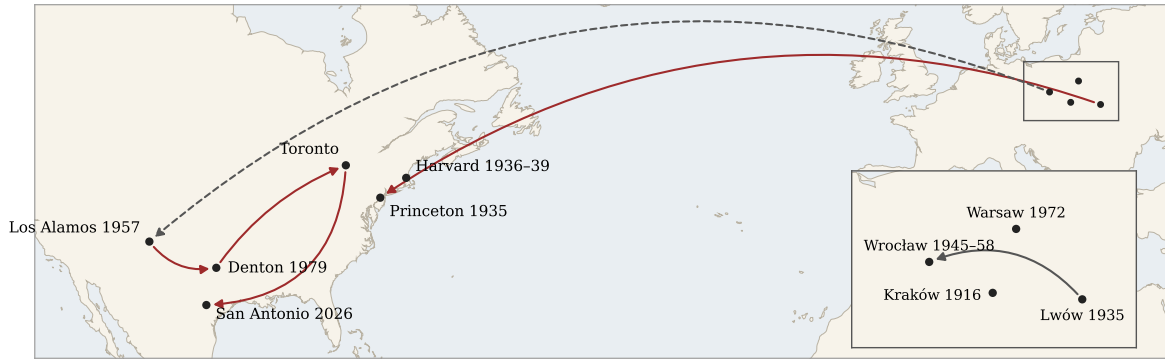


FIGURE 4. The journey of the Scottish Book. Red: Ulam's crossing in 1935, and the road from Los Alamos to Denton, Toronto and San Antonio. Dashed: the handwritten copy that Steinhaus sent from Wrocław to Ulam in 1956. The inset shows Poland: Kraków, where Steinhaus met Banach in 1916; Lwów, home of the Scottish Café; Wrocław, home of the New Scottish Book after the war; and Warsaw, where Enflo received his goose in 1972.

- 1916 Steinhaus meets Banach and Nikodym in the Planty park, Kraków.
- 1920 Banach's doctorate in Lwów, without a university degree.
- 1930 Ulam: no measure on all subsets of the continuum (measurable cardinals).
- 1932 Banach's *Théorie des opérations linéaires*.
- 1935 17 July: Problem 1, by Banach. July: Mazur's Problem 43; 4 August: Banach's answer. End of the year: Ulam goes to Princeton.
- 1936 6 November: Mazur's Problem 153, the goose problem.
- 1939 20 August: Ulam leaves Poland for the last time. September: war.
- 1941 31 May: last problem, number 193, by Steinhaus. July: the Lwów professors are murdered.
- 1945 31 August: Banach dies in Lwów. Steinhaus in Wrocław; the New Scottish Book (to 1958).
- 1946 Ulam's idea of the Monte Carlo method.
- 1957 Ulam's English translation, mimeographed at Los Alamos; Oxtoby publishes Banach's solution of Problem 43.
- 1962 Mycielski and Steinhaus propose the Axiom of Determinacy.
- 1972 Mazur gives Enflo a live goose in Warsaw.
- 1975 Martin proves Borel determinacy.
- 1979 The Scottish Book Conference in Denton, organized by Mauldin.
- 1981 *The Scottish Book*, edited by Mauldin (second edition 2015).
- 1994–98 Distortion problem (Odell–Schlumprecht); Gowers's dichotomy; Fields Medal for Gowers.
- 2026 The UTSA–Toronto seminar.

FIGURE 5. A timeline of the Scottish Book.

in Lwów without a university degree; the thesis, published in 1922, contains what we now call Banach spaces. Steinhaus, who made many contributions to mathematics, later said that Banach was his greatest scientific discovery. Fifteen years later Banach opened the Scottish Book with Problem 1, on when a metric space can be remetrized so as to become complete and compact, and within its first weeks he answered Mazur's Problem 43.

Their real seminar room was the *Kawiarnia Szkocka*, the Scottish Café. The mathematicians spent hours at its tables drinking coffee and writing formulas, as the stories go, directly on the marble tabletops, which were wiped clean when the café closed. To save at least the problems, Banach's wife, Lucja Banachowa, provided a large notebook, which was kept by the headwaiter and brought to the table on request. Ulam recalled one session with Mazur and Banach that lasted seventeen hours, interrupted only for meals [Ula76]. He also recorded Banach's view of what a mathematician does: "Good mathematicians see analogies between theorems or theories, the very best ones see analogies between analogies." Thus was born the *Scottish Book* (*Księga Szkocka*); its first problem, by Banach, is dated 17 July 1935. Problems came with prizes: a cup of coffee, a small beer, five beers, a bottle of wine, 100 grams of caviar, a dinner at the Hotel George, a fondue in Geneva, a bottle of whisky "of measure > 0 " (von Neumann, 1937), a kilo of bacon (Saks, 1940), and, for Mazur's Problem 153 of 6 November 1936, a live goose.



FIGURE 6. Plac Akademicki in Lwów, the square of the Scottish Café, on a hand-coloured postcard of 1909 (Kraków: Wydawnictwo Salonu Malarzy Polskich). National Library of Poland (Polona), public domain.

11. PROBLEM 43

Mazur's Problem 43, the subject of these notes, was written in July 1935, a few days after the book was started, with a bottle of wine as the prize. On 4 August 1935 Banach answered it on the opposite page: "Mazur's conjecture is true" (Figure 1). Banach never published his proof; Oxtoby did, in 1957 [Oxt57]. Ulam proposed a variant in which the players choose binary digits; this "Ulam game" later led Jan Mycielski and Hugo Steinhaus, the founder of

the Lwów School, to propose in 1962 a new axiom for set theory, the *Axiom of Determinacy* [MS62]. A question about the size of sets of real numbers, asked over coffee, had become a question in the foundations of mathematics.

12. VON NEUMANN'S INVITATION AND THE BRIDGE TO AMERICA

John von Neumann met Ulam in Warsaw in 1935 and invited him to spend a few months at the Institute for Advanced Study in Princeton. Ulam, then twenty-six, crossed the Atlantic at the end of 1935.

Ulam was the most prolific author of the Scottish Book: about forty problems are his alone, and some fifteen more are joint with Banach, Mazur and others. He also solved problems there, among them Problem 9, a Helly-type statement on families of finite sets: if each set has at most n elements and any $n + 1$ of them have a common element, then all of them do. His own problems have had a long life. Problem 19 asks whether a solid of uniform density that floats in water in equilibrium in every position must be a ball; in 2022 Dmitry Ryabogin showed that the answer is no: there is a convex body of revolution of density $1/2$, not a ball, with this property [Rya22]. His work of the same years on measures defined on all subsets of a set [Ula30] led to measurable cardinals, and through them to the set-theoretic topology practised at Toronto (see Section 19 below).

At a tea in von Neumann's house, G. D. Birkhoff asked him whether he would like to join the Society of Fellows at Harvard, and for the next few years Ulam divided his time between Harvard and Lwów, returning to Poland each summer and to the tables of the Scottish Café. On 20 August 1939 he sailed for the United States for the last time, taking with him his seventeen-year-old brother Adam. Twelve days later Germany invaded Poland, and on 17 September the Soviet Union followed. Ulam's father Józef, his sister Stefania and much of his family were killed in the Holocaust.

13. WAR, AND THE SURVIVAL OF THE BOOK

The war destroyed the Lwów School. From September 1939 the city was under Soviet occupation, and the café meetings went on; Saks's kilo of bacon dates from 1940. German troops entered Lwów on 30 June 1941. In the night of 3–4 July, in a planned action against the Polish intelligentsia, they arrested professors of the city's universities together with members of their families, and shot them on the Wuleckie Hills: about twenty-five professors and as many relatives died. Among them were the mathematicians Antoni Łomnicki and Włodzimierz Stożek, together with two of Stożek's sons. Kazimierz Bartel, geometer and former prime minister of Poland, was arrested on 2 July and killed later that month.

The killing did not stop there. Stanisław Saks was murdered in Warsaw in 1942. Herman Auerbach took poison in 1942 rather than be deported to a death camp. Juliusz Schauder, the author of the Schauder fixed point theorem, was murdered in 1943. Mark Kac had left for the United States in 1938; his parents and brother were killed in 1942. Steinhaus survived by hiding in the countryside under a false name.

Banach survived because of Rudolf Weigl, a biologist who had developed a vaccine against typhus. The vaccine was grown in lice, and the lice had to be fed on human blood: "louse feeders" let cages of lice feed on their legs. The German army needed the vaccine, so the papers of Weigl's institute protected its workers, and Weigl used this to employ mathematicians, scientists, members of the underground and Jews. Banach and his son were louse feeders, as were several other members of the school. Weigl also smuggled vaccine into the Warsaw

and Lwów ghettos. In 2003 Yad Vashem recognized him as Righteous Among the Nations. Banach lived to see the end of the war; he died of lung cancer in Lwów on 31 August 1945.

The book survived too. Ulam recalled that Mazur had once proposed, in case the city was bombed, to put the manuscripts and the Scottish Book in a case and bury it near a goal post of a football field outside the city; whether this was done is not known. What is known is that after Banach's death his son, Stefan Banach Jr., found the book and showed it to Steinhaus, who had moved to Wrocław. The last entry, Problem 193, had been written by Steinhaus on 31 May 1941.

14. ULAM AFTER LWÓW

The mathematics of the café went on in Ulam's life in unexpected ways. At the end of 1943, on the invitation of Hans Bethe, he joined the Manhattan Project at Los Alamos. In 1946, recovering from a serious illness and playing solitaire, Ulam wondered what the chance of winning a game was, and saw that it was easier to estimate it by playing many random games than by counting. With von Neumann he turned this idea into the *Monte Carlo method*, named by their colleague Nicholas Metropolis after the casino [MU49]; it is now among the most used methods in science. With Edward Teller he took part in the design of the hydrogen bomb. In 1955, with Enrico Fermi and John Pasta, he studied on the MANIAC computer a chain of oscillators that, unexpectedly, did not reach thermal equilibrium [FPU55]. The programs were written by Mary Tsingou, whose role was acknowledged only decades later, when the problem became known as the Fermi–Pasta–Ulam–Tsingou problem [Dau08].

15. THE 1957 LOS ALAMOS MIMEOGRAPH

Steinhaus copied the book by hand and in 1956 sent the copy to Ulam, who was by then at the Los Alamos Scientific Laboratory in New Mexico. Ulam translated it into English and, in his words, “had some three hundred mimeographed copies of the translation made. I had to pay for this myself—Los Alamos is a government laboratory, and one cannot use taxpayers' money for such frivolous purposes.” The copies circulated among mathematicians around the world, and for a generation they were the way most people knew the problems.

16. PROBLEM 153: A LIVE GOOSE ON NATIONAL POLISH TELEVISION

The best known prize of the Scottish Book was paid thirty-six years late. Mazur's Problem 153 of 6 November 1936 asked a question about approximating continuous functions, and offered a live goose. It was soon realized that the problem is equivalent to Grothendieck's approximation problem: does every compact operator on a Banach space lie in the closure of the finite-rank operators? A negative answer would also answer Banach's basis problem. In 1972 the young Swedish mathematician Per Enflo constructed a separable Banach space without the approximation property, and therefore without a Schauder basis [Enf73]. Mazur, then in Warsaw, kept his word: in December 1972, in a ceremony at the Stefan Banach Center, he presented Enflo, then twenty-eight, with a live goose, and the ceremony was broadcast throughout Poland.

Enflo is also a concert pianist. At eleven he won the piano section of Sweden's Mozart competition of 1956, and at sixteen the national competition for young pianists of 1961, whose prize was a summer of study with Géza Anda. He has kept performing ever since.

17. THE ROAD TO DENTON: DAN MAULDIN AND NORTH TEXAS

In the 1970s the story moved to Texas. R. Daniel Mauldin, a measure theorist and descriptive set theorist at North Texas State University (now the University of North Texas) in Denton, took on the task of finding out what had become of the 193 problems. In May 1979 he organized the *Scottish Book Conference* in Denton.

The list of participants reads like a family reunion. Ulam, Mark Kac and Antoni Zygmund, contributors to the original book, came, together with Paul Erdős and Andrzej Granas. R. D. Anderson and D. A. Martin spoke about work that went back to the *Scottish Book*; Martin had proved Borel determinacy in 1975, the theorem that the infinite games descended from Problem 43 are determined whenever the payoff set is Borel. John Oxtoby, who had published Banach's solution of Problem 43, gave the toast, and R. H. Bing, a pillar of Texas topology, also spoke.

From the conference came the book edited by Mauldin, *The Scottish Book: Mathematics from the Scottish Café* (Birkhäuser, 1981) [Mau81]. It contains Ulam's "anecdotal history" of the book, the problems with commentaries on their later history, and papers from the conference. A second edition appeared in 2015 [Mau15].

18. THE NEW SCOTTISH BOOK

The tradition did not die in Lwów. In Wrocław, where much of the Lwów university was re-established after the war, Steinhaus started the *New Scottish Book* (*Nowa Księga Szkocka*), which collected problems from 1945 to 1958. The second edition of Mauldin's book includes a history of the New Scottish Book and selected problems from it.

19. THE CONNECTION TO SET-THEORETIC TOPOLOGY AND RAMSEY SPACES AT TORONTO

The questions of the *Scottish Book* on measure, category and infinite games also run through set-theoretic topology, a field in which the University of Toronto has long been a leading centre.

In 1930 Ulam proved that there is no nontrivial countably additive measure defined on all subsets of the continuum unless the continuum is very large, introducing in the process what are now called Ulam matrices and measurable cardinals [Ula30]. Large cardinals of this kind became a standard tool for consistency proofs in topology. At Toronto, Franklin D. Tall and his collaborators applied such set-theoretic methods to classical problems of point-set topology, most notably the normal Moore space problem. Infinite games of the Banach–Mazur type, and their relatives such as the Menger and Rothberger games of Part II, are now everyday tools in the field.

Stevo Todorcevic, at Toronto, developed the theory of Ramsey spaces, which unifies the Galvin–Prikry and Ellentuck theorems, Gowers's theorem and much else in a single axiomatic framework [Tod10]. The circle closes in the present: Tall is a coauthor, with Eduardo Dueñez and José Iovino of UT San Antonio, of recent work on the complexity of deep computations through the topology of function spaces [DnIMW⁺26], the subject of the seminar for which these notes were written.

20. THE TRIUMPH OF GAMES: COMBINATORICS, LOGIC, AND THE REAL-VALUED SETTING

Texas also became a centre of the Banach space theory that Banach's 1932 monograph and the Scottish Book had launched. Edward Odell at the University of Texas at Austin and Thomas Schlumprecht at Texas A&M University were at the heart of it.

In 1991 Schlumprecht constructed the first arbitrarily distortable Banach space [Sch91], and in 1994 Odell and Schlumprecht used his ideas to solve the distortion problem: the Hilbert space ℓ_2 is itself arbitrarily distortable [OS94]. Schlumprecht's space was also the starting point of W. T. Gowers and B. Maurey, who in 1993 answered the old unconditional basic sequence problem by constructing a "hereditarily indecomposable" space, a space in which no infinite-dimensional subspace has an unconditional basis [GM93].

The last step needed a different kind of mathematics. Banach's homogeneous space problem, from his 1932 monograph, asks whether ℓ_2 is the only infinite-dimensional Banach space isomorphic to all of its infinite-dimensional closed subspaces. To answer it, Gowers turned to infinite combinatorics and logic.

The bridge was infinite-dimensional Ramsey theory. Ramsey's 1930 theorem concerns colourings of finite subsets of $\mathbb{N}$ [Ram30]; extending it to colourings of infinite subsets runs into the axiom of choice, which produces colourings with no homogeneous infinite set. Galvin and Prikry showed in 1973 that every Borel colouring of $[\mathbb{N}]^\infty$ does have one [GP73]; Silver extended this to analytic sets [Sil70], and Ellentuck characterized the Ramsey sets topologically [Ell74]. These are theorems of set theory and descriptive set theory, proved by logicians.

Gowers saw that this machinery could be imported into Banach space theory if it was translated into a continuous, real-valued setting. In place of infinite subsets of $\mathbb{N}$ he considered block sequences of vectors, and in place of choosing integers he set up an infinite two-player game: Player I plays infinite-dimensional block subspaces, and Player II answers with vectors in them. His Ramsey theorem for this game yields the Dichotomy Theorem: every infinite-dimensional Banach space contains either a subspace with an unconditional basis or a hereditarily indecomposable subspace [Gow96]. Combined with a theorem of Komorowski and Tomczak-Jaegermann [KTJ95], this shows that every homogeneous Banach space is isomorphic to ℓ_2 .

When Gowers received the Fields Medal in 1998, the cycle was complete. Infinite games, born at a café table in Lwów in 1935, had passed through the foundations of mathematics (determinacy), through the hands of logicians and combinatorialists (infinite Ramsey theory), and through Texas, Paris, Cambridge and Toronto, and had come back to analysis to settle a problem posed by Banach himself. The notebook that survived a war, and the people who survived it, or did not, and the colleagues who carried their problems across an ocean, are part of that triumph.

21. PROPOSAL: A SCOTTISH BOOK OF OUR OWN

The Scottish Book was not a journal. It was a notebook on a café table, open to anyone who sat down, where a problem could be written before it was understood and a prize could be a beer or a goose. That spirit is easy to revive. We propose that the participants of this seminar, in San Antonio and in Toronto, keep a Scottish Book of their own: a shared notebook of problems that come up in our discussions, each signed and dated, with a prize chosen by its author, and with room for the answers, partial results and counterexamples that follow. Students are especially welcome to contribute; Ulam was twenty-six when he

wrote in the original book, and some of its best problems are short questions anyone can state.

FURTHER READING

Ulam’s autobiography [Ula76] and Kac’s [Kac85] are the best first-hand accounts of the Lwów School and of what came after. Kałuža’s biography of Banach [Kal96] tells the story of Banach’s life and of the city. Mauldin’s book [Mau81, Mau15] contains the problems themselves, with commentaries on what became of them.



FIGURE 7. Stanisław Ulam in 1962. Photograph by Alfred Eisenstaedt for *LIFE*, from a series of portraits of mathematicians that Eisenstaedt made for the magazine in 1962–63, which also includes Kurt Gödel and Claude Shannon.

Appendix: Applications of non-topological games

The games in this appendix are not played with open sets at all: they are finite games on boards, or games played with elements of two structures. They are included because they are too beautiful to leave out, and because they show the same two features of games (local decisions, combinable strategies) at work far from topology.

APPENDIX A. APPLICATIONS TO THE PROBABILISTIC METHOD

The problem. The probabilistic method proves that combinatorial objects exist by showing that a random object has the required property with positive probability. For example, Erdős proved in 1963 that if a family $\mathcal{F}$ of n -element sets has fewer than 2^{n-1} members, then the elements can be coloured red and blue so that no member of $\mathcal{F}$ is monochromatic: a random colouring makes a given set monochromatic with probability 2^{1-n} , so the expected number of monochromatic sets is less than 1. Such proofs give no construction. The problem is to turn them into explicit, deterministic, efficient constructions.

✂ **A.1. History of the problem and of the solution using combinatorial games.** The probabilistic method was introduced by Erdős in 1947, in his lower bound for diagonal Ramsey numbers [Erd47], and the colouring theorem above is from 1963 [Erd63]. In 1973 Erdős and Selfridge studied Maker–Breaker games, in which the players alternately claim elements of a board and Maker tries to claim all the elements of some winning set [ES73]. They gave a strategy for Breaker based on a potential function equal to the expected number of winning sets that Maker would complete if the rest of the game were played at random, and showed that Breaker can keep this expectation from growing. Their argument gives the solution for the colouring theorem and related results: the same potential argument, with one player instead of two, colours the elements one at a time and never lets the expected number of monochromatic sets reach 1.

The argument was recognized as a general derandomization technique, the method of conditional probabilities, systematized by Spencer in 1987 [Spe87] and extended by Raghavan’s pessimistic estimators in 1988 [Rag88]. Beck built on the Erdős–Selfridge theorem a theory of positional games, presented in his book of 2008 [Bec08].

Recognition. Erdős received the Wolf Prize in 1983/84.

A.2. The game. Let $\mathcal{F}$ be a family of subsets of a finite set V . In the *Maker–Breaker game* on $(V, \mathcal{F})$, Maker is Player I and Breaker is Player II. Tic-tac-toe is the example to keep in mind: the set V is the board and $\mathcal{F}$ is the set of lines. The players alternately claim unclaimed elements of V , Player I first, until all elements are claimed. Player I wins if he has claimed all the elements of some $A \in \mathcal{F}$, and Player II wins otherwise.

A.3. The Main Result of this section. The main result is the Erdős–Selfridge theorem and two classical consequences.

Theorem A.1 (Erdős–Selfridge, 1973). *Let $\mathcal{F}$ be a family of subsets of a finite set V .*

- (1) *If $\sum_{A \in \mathcal{F}} 2^{-|A|} < \frac{1}{2}$, then in the Maker–Breaker game on $(V, \mathcal{F})$ in which Maker moves first, Breaker has a winning strategy.*
- (2) *If $\sum_{A \in \mathcal{F}} 2^{1-|A|} < 1$, then a colouring of V in two colours with no monochromatic member of $\mathcal{F}$ can be computed in time polynomial in $|V|$ and $|\mathcal{F}|$.*
- (3) *In tic-tac-toe on the board $\{1, \dots, n\}^d$, the first player cannot force a win when $\frac{1}{2}((n+2)^d - n^d) < 2^{n-1}$.*

Part (3) follows from part (1) because the board has $\frac{1}{2}((n+2)^d - n^d)$ lines of n cells each: the second player uses Breaker’s strategy and occupies a cell of every line. By the Hales–Jewett theorem (1963), on the other hand, the first player wins when d is large compared with n [HJ63].

A.4. How the game solves the problem. At any stage we call $A \in \mathcal{F}$ *alive* if Player II has claimed none of the elements of A , let $u(A)$ be the number of unclaimed elements of A , and set

$$\Phi = \sum_{A \text{ alive}} 2^{-u(A)}, \quad w(v) = \sum_{A \text{ alive}, v \in A} 2^{-u(A)}.$$

If the remaining elements were assigned to the two players by fair coin tosses, the quantity Φ would be the expected number of sets completed by Player I. Initially $\Phi < \frac{1}{2}$, and after Player I's first move $\Phi < 1$. A claim of v by Player I increases Φ by $w(v)$, and a claim by Player II decreases Φ by $w(v)$. Player II always claims an element of maximal weight. Then Player I's next claim increases Φ by at most that maximal weight, because weights only decrease when Player II moves, so Φ never increases over a pair of moves and stays below 1. If Player I completed a set A , the term of A in Φ would be $2^0 = 1$, which is impossible. For part (2) one player colours the elements one at a time, choosing at each step the colour that does not increase the expected number of monochromatic sets; the expectation starts below 1, never increases, and at the end is an integer, hence 0. This is not just an existence proof: the argument is an explicit polynomial-time algorithm, short enough to write in a few lines of Python.

The point of view of games adds robustness. A probabilistic argument shows that a random play is good on average; the game shows that a good outcome can be forced one move at a time, even against an adversary who chooses half of the moves. This is what makes the argument both constructive and efficient.

APPENDIX B. APPLICATIONS TO FIXED POINT THEORY

The problem. The *Brouwer fixed point theorem* says that every continuous map $f: [0, 1]^n \rightarrow [0, 1]^n$ has a fixed point. The original proofs used algebraic topology. The problem is to find an elementary, combinatorial proof that exposes the finite core of the theorem and, ideally, yields a method for locating approximate fixed points.

✂ **B.1. History of the problem and of the solution using combinatorial games.** The theorem was proved in general by Hadamard in 1910 and Brouwer in 1912 [Bro12], by methods of the new algebraic topology. A combinatorial proof was given by Sperner in 1928 [Spe28], through his lemma on labelled triangulations, and Scarf turned this line of thought into an algorithm for computing approximate fixed points in 1967 [Sca67]. Meanwhile the game of Hex was invented by Piet Hein in 1942 and, independently, by John Nash at Princeton in 1948. Nash observed that the game cannot end in a draw and, by a strategy-stealing argument, that the first player has a winning strategy.

The game-theoretic solution was found by David Gale in 1979 [Gal79], who proved that the Brouwer fixed point theorem is an easy consequence of the fact that Hex cannot end in a draw, and extended both statements to n dimensions.

Recognition. Gale's paper, in the *American Mathematical Monthly*, received a Lester R. Ford Award of the Mathematical Association of America in 1980, the year in which Gale shared the John von Neumann Theory Prize. Nash received the Nobel Memorial Prize in Economic Sciences in 1994 and the Abel Prize in 2015.

B.2. The game. Hex is played on a rhombus-shaped board of hexagonal cells, and anyone who has played Hex knows the feeling that somebody *must* win: if you have blocked your opponent completely, you seem to have connected your own sides. Fix $k \geq 1$. We describe the board by the centres of the cells. The cells are the points (i, j) with $1 \leq i, j \leq k$, and

(i, j) is adjacent to $(i \pm 1, j)$, $(i, j \pm 1)$, $(i + 1, j + 1)$ and $(i - 1, j - 1)$. Player I owns the bottom and top rows (where $j = 1$ and $j = k$), and Player II the left and right columns (where $i = 1$ and $i = k$). The players alternately place stones on empty cells, Player I first. Player I wins if his stones contain a chain of adjacent cells from bottom to top, and Player II wins if hers contain one from left to right.

B.3. The Main Result of this section. The main result is the Hex theorem and, as a consequence, the fixed point theorem in dimension two.

Theorem B.1 (Gale, 1979).

- (1) The Hex theorem. *If every cell of a $k \times k$ Hex board is occupied by a stone of Player I or of Player II, then exactly one of the players has a chain of his or her stones joining his or her two sides of the board.*
- (2) *The Hex theorem implies the Brouwer fixed point theorem for $[0, 1]^2$.*

Gale proved the corresponding statements for an n -dimensional version of Hex and $[0, 1]^n$.

B.4. How the game solves the problem.

No draws. Gale follows the boundary between the two colours. Add an extra row of Player I's stones above and below the board, and an extra column of Player II's on either side. Start at a corner of the enlarged board, between the two colours, and walk along the edges of the hexagons that separate a stone of Player I from one of Player II. At each vertex three cells meet, two of one colour and one of the other, so the walk continues in exactly one way and never returns to a vertex. Since the board is finite, the walk must leave the board at another corner, and the stones of one colour along one side of the walk form a winning chain. The two players cannot both win, because a top-to-bottom chain and a left-to-right chain would have to cross, and on the hexagonal board crossing chains share a cell.

Brouwer's theorem. Suppose that $f = (f_1, f_2): [0, 1]^2 \rightarrow [0, 1]^2$ has no fixed point. By compactness there is $\varepsilon > 0$ with $\max_i |f_i(z) - z_i| \geq \varepsilon$ for all z , and by uniform continuity there is $\delta < \varepsilon$ with $|f_i(z) - f_i(z')| < \varepsilon$ whenever $|z - z'|_\infty \leq \delta$. Choose k with $1/(k-1) \leq \delta$, and place at each cell (i, j) the point $z = ((i-1)/(k-1), (j-1)/(k-1))$. Give the cell to Player II if $|f_1(z) - z_1| \geq \varepsilon$, and to Player I otherwise, in which case $|f_2(z) - z_2| \geq \varepsilon$. By the Hex theorem one of the players has a winning chain. Say Player II has a chain from left to right. On the left side $z_1 = 0 \leq f_1(z)$, so there $f_1(z) - z_1 \geq \varepsilon$; on the right side $z_1 = 1 \geq f_1(z)$, so there $z_1 - f_1(z) \geq \varepsilon$. Along the chain the sign changes, so two adjacent cells z, z' satisfy $f_1(z) - z_1 \geq \varepsilon$ and $z'_1 - f_1(z') \geq \varepsilon$. Adding these inequalities, we obtain $(f_1(z) - f_1(z')) + (z'_1 - z_1) \geq 2\varepsilon$, which is impossible because both terms are less than ε . A chain of Player I leads to the same contradiction with f_2 .

The point of view of games is that the topological content of the theorem is the statement that a game cannot end in a draw. Read in the contrapositive, the argument shows that for every $\varepsilon > 0$ some point z of a sufficiently fine grid satisfies $|f(z) - z|_\infty < \varepsilon$, and the fixed point is obtained by compactness. This finite form is the one in which combinatorial proofs of fixed point theorems, from Sperner's lemma to Scarf's algorithm, are used in computation.

APPENDIX C. APPLICATIONS TO MODEL THEORY

The problem. Two structures $\mathcal{A}$ and $\mathcal{B}$ in the same signature are *elementarily equivalent*, written $\mathcal{A} \equiv \mathcal{B}$, if they satisfy the same first-order sentences. The problem is to find a method, not requiring the inspection of all sentences, for deciding whether two given structures are elementarily equivalent, and, dually, for proving that a given property of structures cannot be expressed by a first-order sentence.

✂ **C.1. History of the problem and of the solution using combinatorial games.** Elementary equivalence was introduced by Tarski, whose programme of the 1930s to 1950s of classifying the complete first-order theories of familiar structures required tools for proving that two structures satisfy the same sentences. The back-and-forth method, which goes back to Cantor's theorem of 1895 that any two countable dense linear orders without endpoints are isomorphic, suggested the answer.

The problem was solved by Roland Fraïssé in 1954 [Fra54], who characterized elementary equivalence by systems of partial isomorphisms, and the solution was recast as a game by Andrzej Ehrenfeucht in 1961 [Ehr61], who used the game to prove completeness and decidability of theories. In finite model theory, which developed from the 1970s onward in connection with databases and computational complexity, these games became the principal method for proving that properties are not definable in a given logic; Fagin, for instance, used games of this kind in 1975 to show that connectivity of finite graphs is not expressible in monadic existential second-order logic [Fag75].

C.2. The game. Let $\mathcal{A}$ and $\mathcal{B}$ be structures in the same finite relational signature, and let $n \geq 0$ be given. The game $\text{EF}_n(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{B})$ has n rounds. The names used in the literature describe the game well: Player I is the *Spoiler*, who wants to expose a difference between the two structures, and Player II is the *Duplicator*, who wants to show that they look alike. In round k , Player I chooses one of the two structures and an element of that structure, and Player II answers with an element of the other structure. After n rounds the players have produced $a_1, \dots, a_n \in \mathcal{A}$ and $b_1, \dots, b_n \in \mathcal{B}$, and Player II wins if the map $a_k \mapsto b_k$ is a partial isomorphism, that is, if the a_k and the b_k satisfy the same atomic formulas.

C.3. The Main Result of this section. The main result is the theorem of Fraïssé and Ehrenfeucht. Write $\mathcal{A} \equiv_n \mathcal{B}$ if $\mathcal{A}$ and $\mathcal{B}$ satisfy the same first-order sentences of quantifier rank at most n .

Theorem C.1 (Fraïssé, 1954; Ehrenfeucht, 1961). *Let $\mathcal{A}$ and $\mathcal{B}$ be structures in a finite relational signature, and let $n \geq 0$ be given. Then $\mathcal{A} \equiv_n \mathcal{B}$ if and only if Player II has a winning strategy in the game $\text{EF}_n(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{B})$ of the preceding subsection. Consequently, we have $\mathcal{A} \equiv \mathcal{B}$ if and only if Player II has a winning strategy in $\text{EF}_n(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{B})$ for every n .*

Two standard applications show how the theorem is used. First, the orders $(\mathbb{Q}, <)$ and $(\mathbb{R}, <)$ are elementarily equivalent. Second, if L_m denotes the linear order with m elements, then $L_m \equiv_n L_{m'}$ whenever $m, m' \geq 2^n$; hence no first-order sentence is true exactly in the finite linear orders of even size, and, by a standard interpretation of graphs in linear orders, connectivity of finite graphs is not first-order expressible.

C.4. How the game solves the problem.

The theorem. The proof of Theorem C.1 is by induction on n , and the game is a direct picture of the quantifiers. A sentence of quantifier rank n is a Boolean combination of sentences $\exists x \psi(x)$ with ψ of quantifier rank $n - 1$. If $\mathcal{A} \models \exists x \psi(x)$ but $\mathcal{B} \not\models \exists x \psi(x)$, Player I plays a witness $a \in \mathcal{A}$ of ψ , and whatever Player II answers in $\mathcal{B}$ fails ψ ; by induction Player I wins the remaining $n - 1$ rounds. Conversely, in a finite relational signature there are only finitely many formulas of each quantifier rank up to equivalence, so the rank- $(n - 1)$ type of an element is expressed by a single formula, and Player II answers each move with an element of the same type. A statement about all first-order sentences is thus replaced by a finite combinatorial task: finding a strategy.

The applications. In $(\mathbb{Q}, <)$ and $(\mathbb{R}, <)$, whatever element Player I chooses, Player II can choose an element in the same position relative to the elements already played, because both orders are dense and have no endpoints; this back-and-forth argument wins every EF_n . For finite linear orders, Player II keeps the following invariant after round k : any two consecutive chosen elements, including two imaginary elements placed just below the least and just above the greatest element, are at equal distances in the two orders, or at distances that are both at least 2^{n-k} . The intuition: two elements at distance at least 2^{n-k} look infinitely far apart to a formula that has only $n - k$ quantifiers left to inspect them, since each quantifier can at best halve the distance. When Player I plays inside a long gap, Player II can split the corresponding gap so that the invariant persists, and the invariant guarantees that the final map preserves order. So a property that separates L_m from $L_{m'}$ with $m, m' \geq 2^n$ needs quantifier rank greater than n ; since the sizes of finite orders are unbounded, parity needs unbounded quantifier rank, and parity is not first-order expressible.

Ultrapowers. Ultrafilters give a second answer to the problem, algebraic where Theorem C.1 is combinatorial: Keisler proved in 1961, assuming the generalized continuum hypothesis, and Shelah proved in ZFC in 1971, that two structures are elementarily equivalent if and only if they have isomorphic ultrapowers [Kei61, She71]. One direction is Łoś’s theorem, which embeds every structure elementarily in each of its ultrapowers. For the other, Keisler lets λ be an infinite cardinal at least as large as the structures and the signature, and takes a countably incomplete λ^+ -good ultrafilter $\mathcal{D}$ on λ . Such ultrafilters exist under GCH by Keisler’s theorem of 1964, and in ZFC by Kunen’s theorem of 1972 [Kun72], whose proof manufactures them from an independent family of 2^λ subsets of λ . The ultrapowers $\mathcal{A}^\lambda/\mathcal{D}$ and $\mathcal{B}^\lambda/\mathcal{D}$ of infinite structures $\mathcal{A} \equiv \mathcal{B}$ are then λ^+ -saturated and have cardinality 2^λ , which equals λ^+ under GCH. Now the game comes back, played for λ^+ rounds instead of n . In the Ehrenfeucht–Fraïssé game of length λ^+ between the two ultrapowers, Player II answers each move by realizing, in the other structure, the type of the new element over the fewer than λ^+ elements already chosen; saturation guarantees that she can, and if both players enumerate their structures in turn, the play is an isomorphism. Shelah removed GCH by building the ultrafilter and the isomorphism together, in a single transfinite construction of length 2^λ .

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